



User Research

Research Synthesis

with Aurélie Glorieux

Service Design Lead & Design Thinking Expert

Introduction

01

Planning

Session 3

Nov 2, 2025

Introduction to Design Thinking & Interview

- Design thinking methodology for technology solutions
- Empathy building techniques for understanding stakeholder needs
- Designing and conducting qualitative interviews and ethnographic studies

Session 4

Nov 12th, 2025

Research Synthesis

- Synthesizing qualitative research into actionable insights
- Persona development methodology
- User journey mapping

Deliverables



Interview Report

- One interview report per interview with key learning (cf. template)

User Insights

- Create one good insight out of the research data

Personas

- One user persona

User Journey

- Create a user journey as-is

Skills & aptitude

Curiosity & objectivity

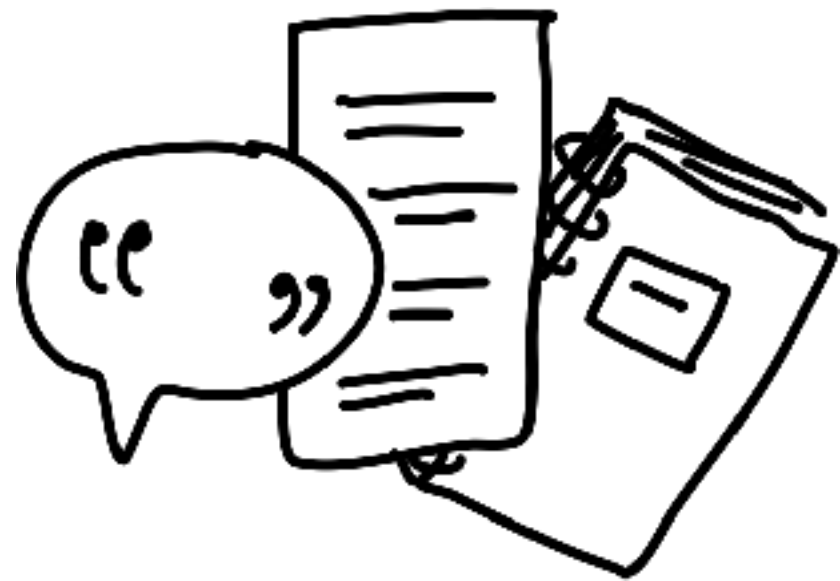
Empathy

Analytical skills

Critical Thinking

Communication

Team Work





Understand



Plan



Research



Synthesize

Envision



Inspire



Generate

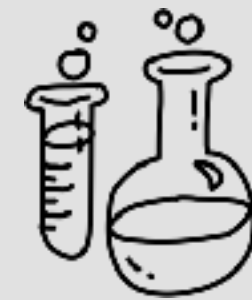


Select

Prototype



Make



Test



Learn

Design Research

Design Research



Research Process Map

Understand



Secondary research



Defining objectives

Prepare

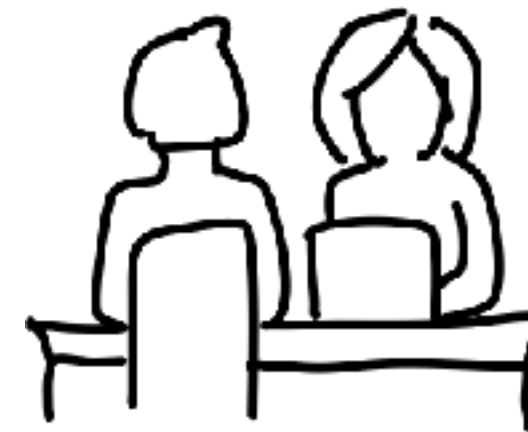


Planning & Budget



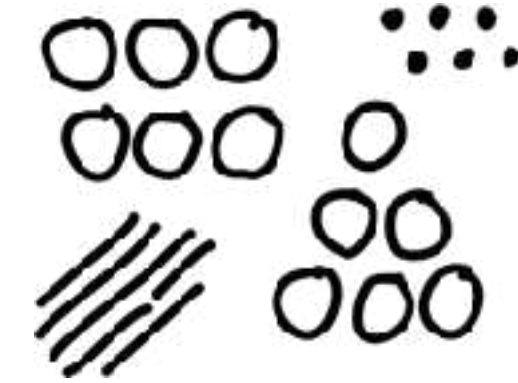
Material & stimuli
for Interview

Explore



User Interviews

Analyse



Synthesis



Models

Purpose

**Fieldwork is one of the sources of
inspiration in the creative process**

Purpose

Fieldwork is one of the sources of inspiration in the creative process, because it helps understand the context, redefine the problems and generate better challenges.

Qualitative research gives us a deeper understanding of human behavior.

We investigate **why** and **how** decisions are made, not only what, where and when.

Design Research Methods

Recommended Download >>>



Research Process Map



Research Synthesis Process

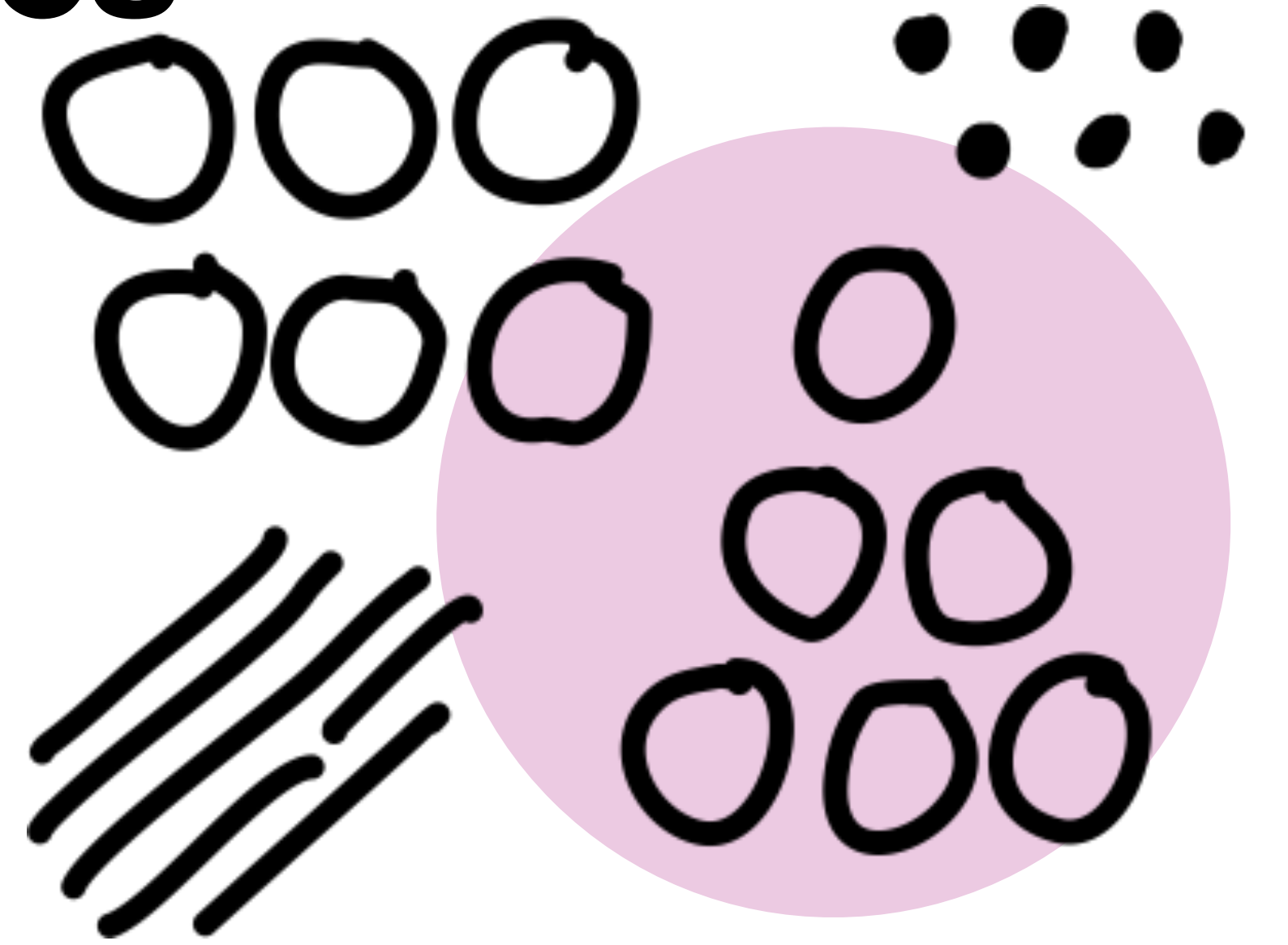
or

How should we eat this?

We need to synthesize raw data - and create action-enabling, inspiring insights



**Synthesis =
taking raw data and identifying the
patterns, themes, and messages
that matter**



Typical synthesis process



Get it all out

Collect all relevant research inputs and data.



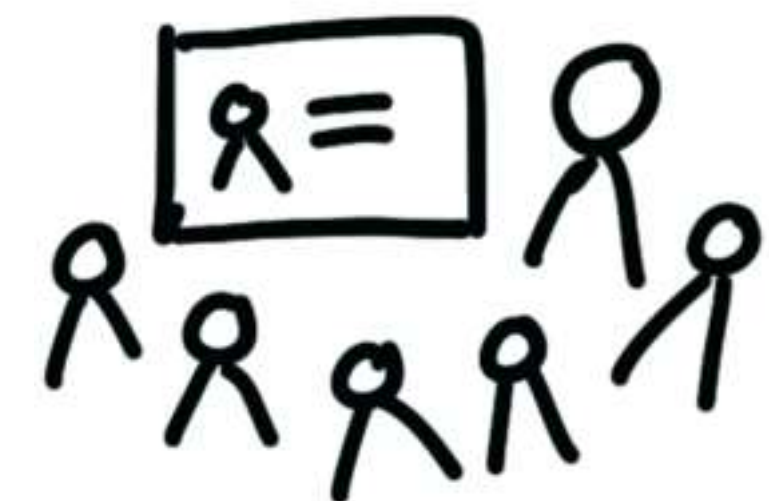
Find themes, patterns and relationships

See what the research is telling you.



Create a model

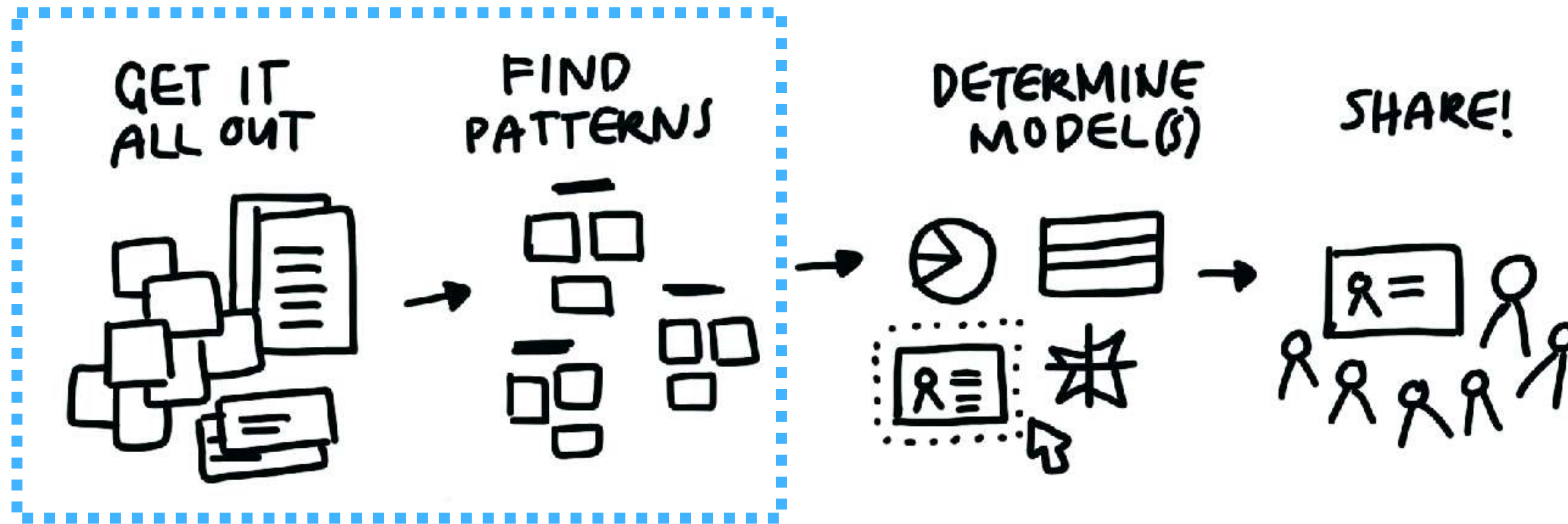
What is the best representation(s) of the research findings?



Share

Communicate research to inspire action.

A general approach to synthesis



Understand

Synthesis model



20 minutes

Synthesize

- **(5 minutes) Data Entry:**

Individually, think and write at least **3 key findings** on a post-it each. Add your most relevant notes (quotes etc.)

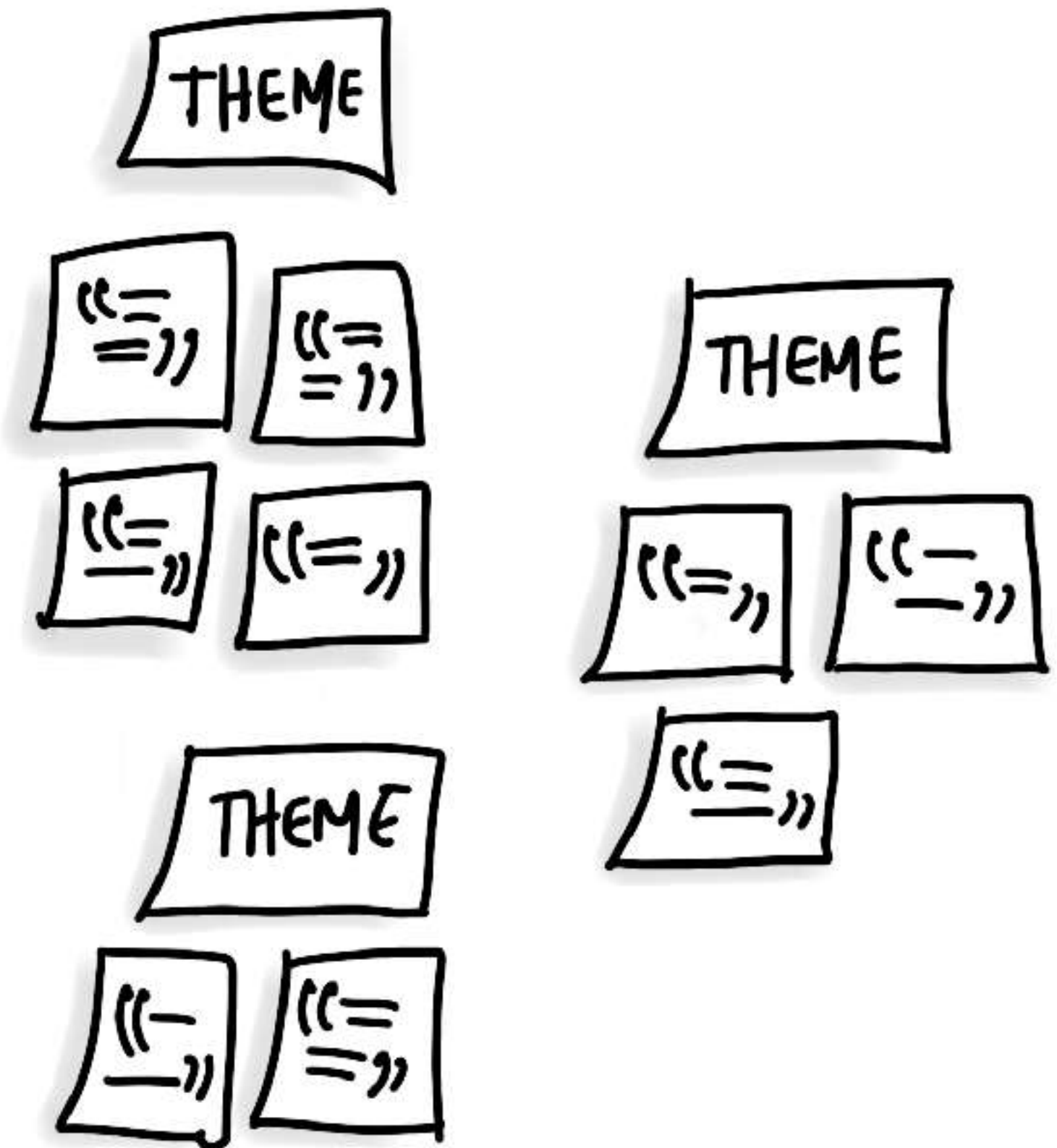
- **(10 minutes) Sharing**

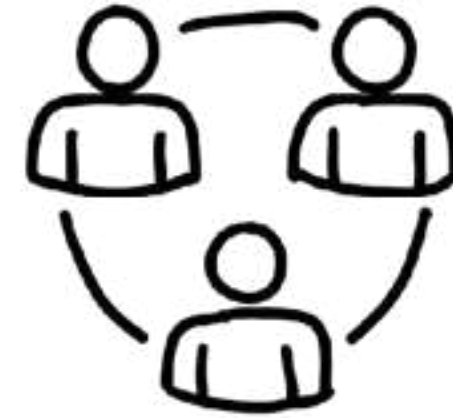
In your group, **share your Post-its out loud** and stick on a flipchart.

- **(5 minutes) Find patterns:**

Then, in group organize your Post-its **per topics** (ex. Health, Food, Behaviours...)

- Use another Post-it to label your themes when you're done.



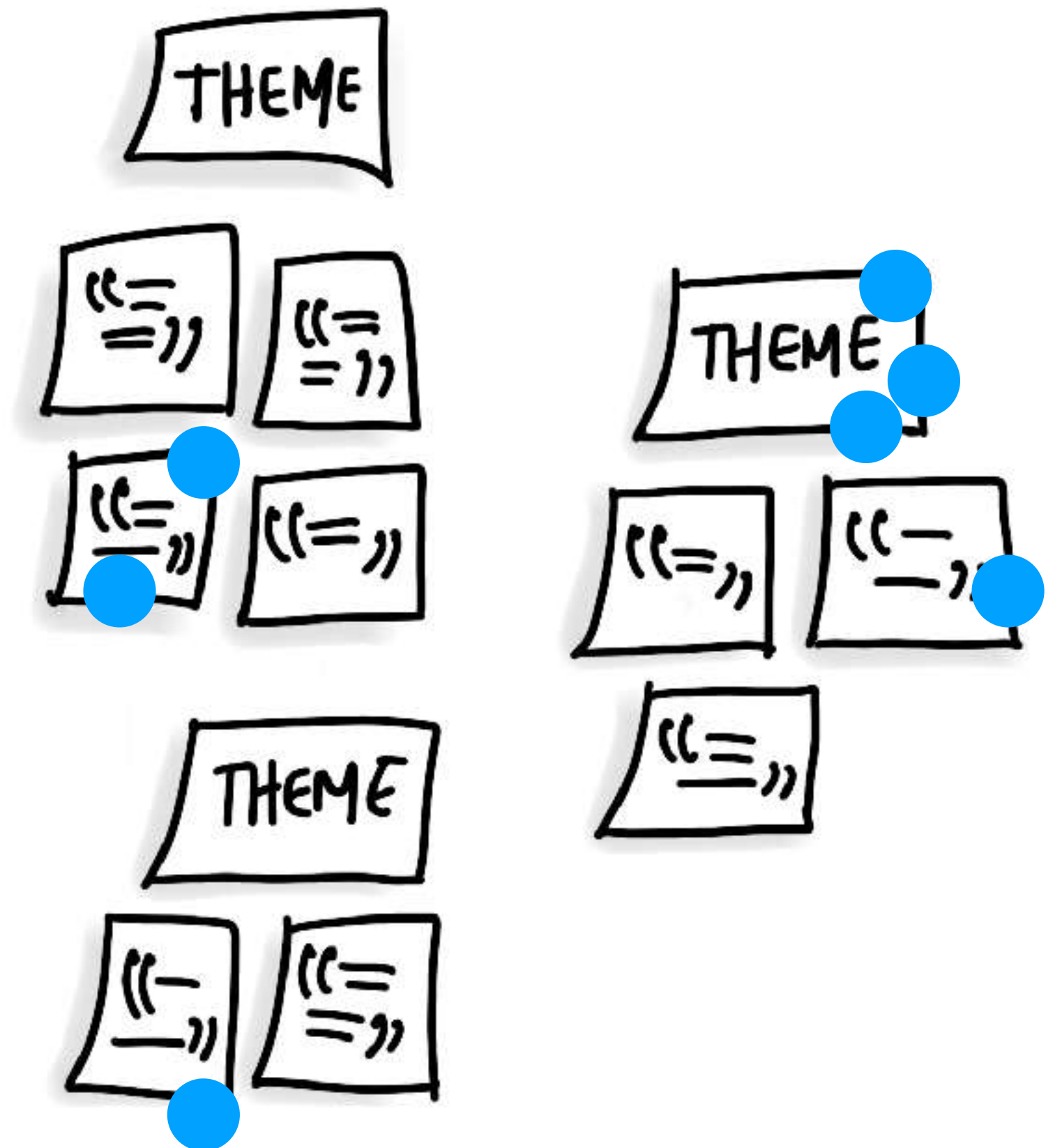


5 minutes

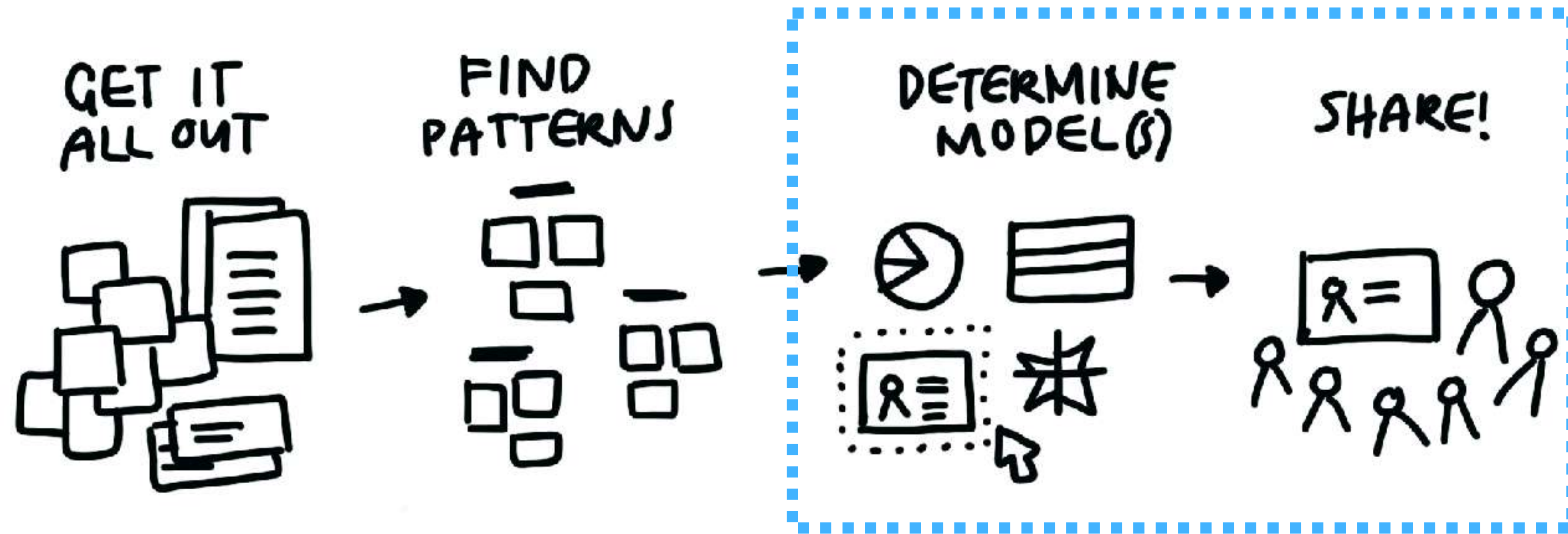
Select & identify key finding

With 3 red dots per person

- Individually, select the 3 most relevant or critical painpoints or needs that you would like to solve.
- In group, share why you think it is an opportunity to the rest of the group



A general approach to synthesis



Understand

Synthesis model

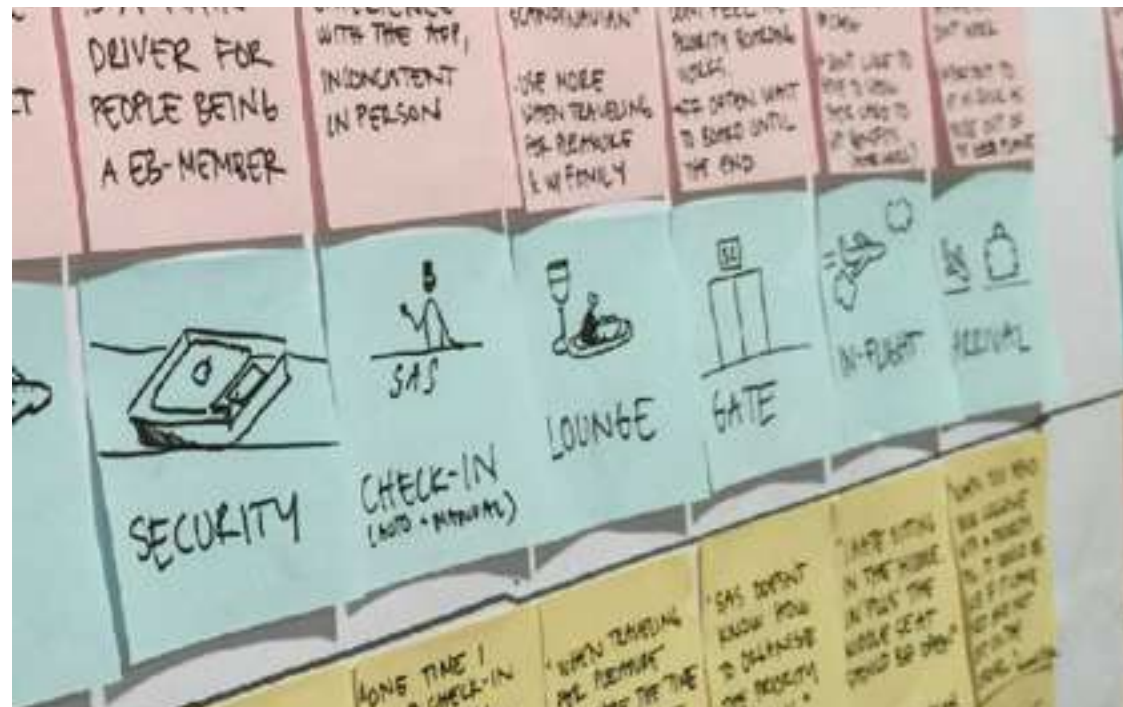
We create models, which communicate and build understanding of the data.

Models are tools to inspire informed action.

Understand Synthesis

Synthesis

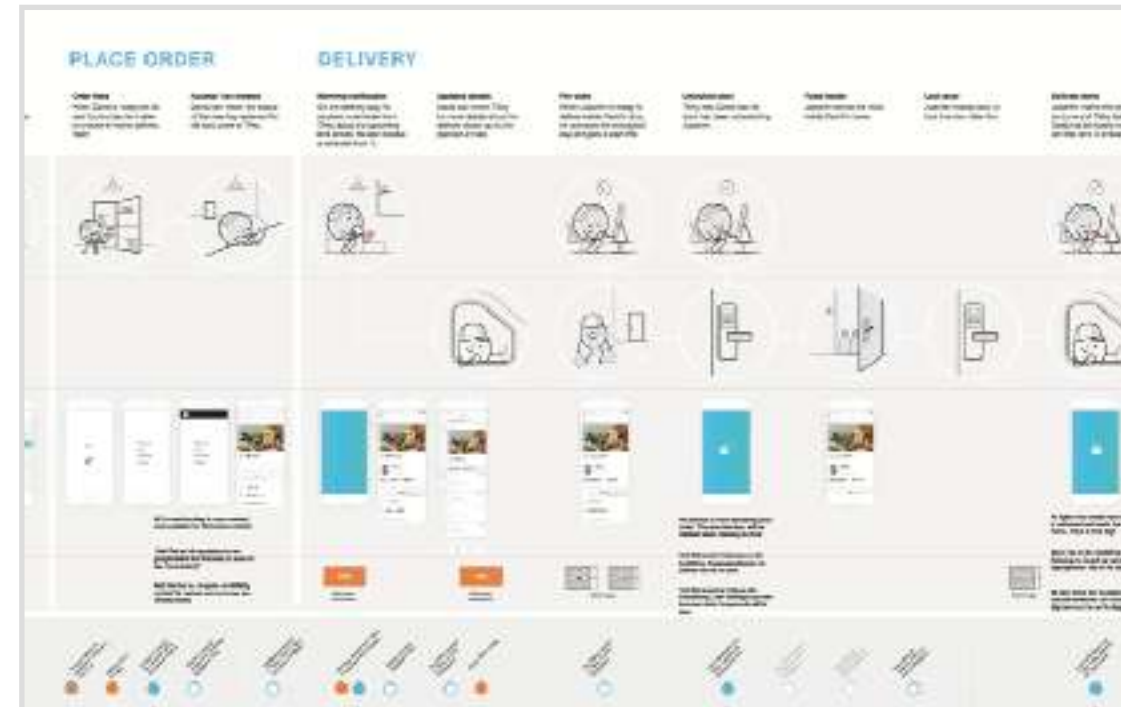
Synthesis models



Key insights



Personas



Journey maps

Understand

Generating Insights

What are the main findings and how to presents them in an effective way?

How should we eat this?

What are the insights within the themes?

How do we present those insights effectively?



Analysis

**Key insights =
actionable, research-driven
findings that create value**



Understand

Synthesis

Look across your Post-its and find **patterns**
in: behaviors, attitudes, pain points, goals ...

It'll feel like a big mess at first, you'll
gradually create order ...

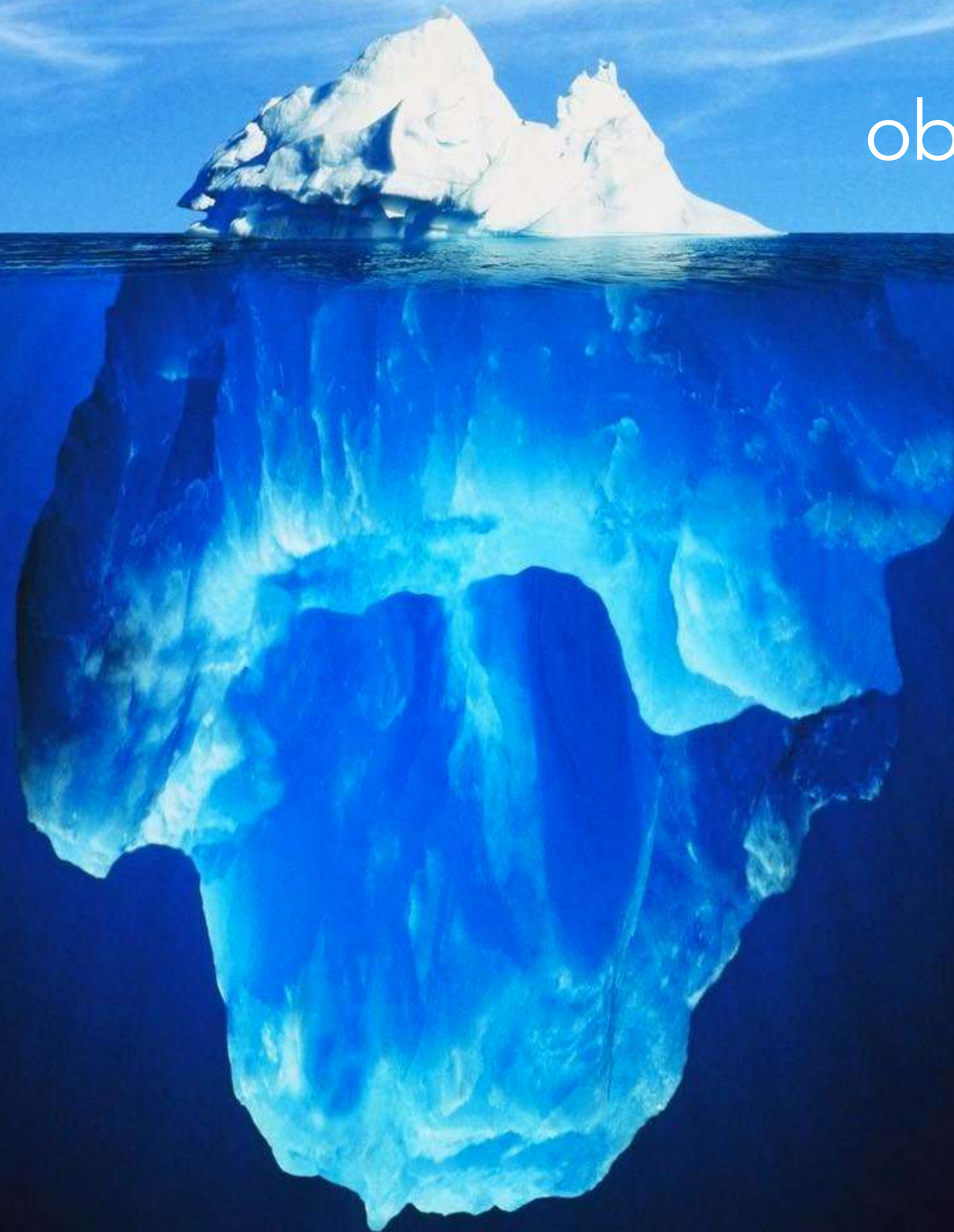
Analysis

What is an insight?

Analysis

conversation

observation



Analysis

conversation

observation

motivations

values

beliefs

behaviors

meanings

problems

needs

potential
insight

Analysis

Example

Conversation

The students say that the mid-morning break is very important to relieve their hunger and keep up their energy in class during the morning.

Observation

Most students don't eat anything during the mid-morning break, they use the time to chat with friends.

Insight

The mid-morning break is a social moment. What gives the students the energy to carry on with classes is being able to switch off mentally while they socialize with their friends.

Insights are not...

~~Ideas or solutions~~

The insight is what begins to build the bridge toward solutions, opening up areas of opportunity

~~Descriptions~~

You don't find insights, you build them. By creating relationships and links between details, in a contextualized manner and generally in connection with people.

~~Conclusions~~

A good insight needs tension. It touches the Achilles heel of some issue. It is even uncomfortable for the client.

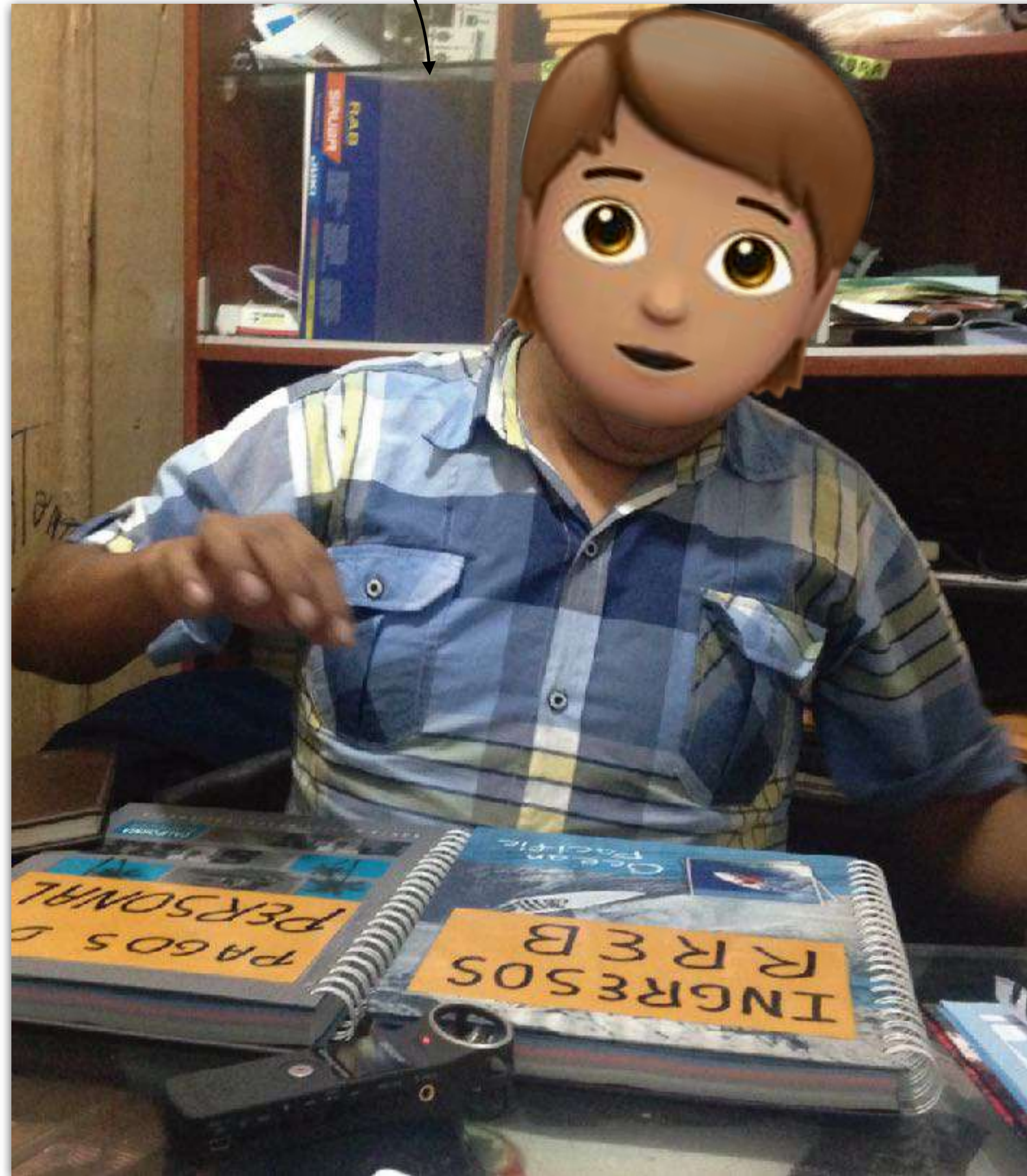
Example

~~Student should be provided with longer break at mid morning.~~

~~Most student told the break moment is important to them.~~

~~Therefore, break moments are important to student.~~

Make it visual



Short & direct statement

**Technology isn't a
micro-businessperson's
business**

Show examples that
support the statement

*I'm not used to using the computer
and sometimes I haven't got much
time to sit there.*

*I'd like to learn computing to do my
invoices and keep in touch with my
relatives abroad.*

*Later on I'm planning on buying
some computers and cameras for
the store, but first I have to learn
computing.*

I'm planning on buying some
computers but first I have to
learn computing

I'd like to learn computing to do
my bills

I haven't got time to sit in front
of a computer

But has a smartphone he uses
to advertise his products
through the social media

Good insights:

- Come from research
- Tell us something new
- Have a point of view
- Sticky and inspiring
- Actionable



Understand

Your challenge

Generating insights



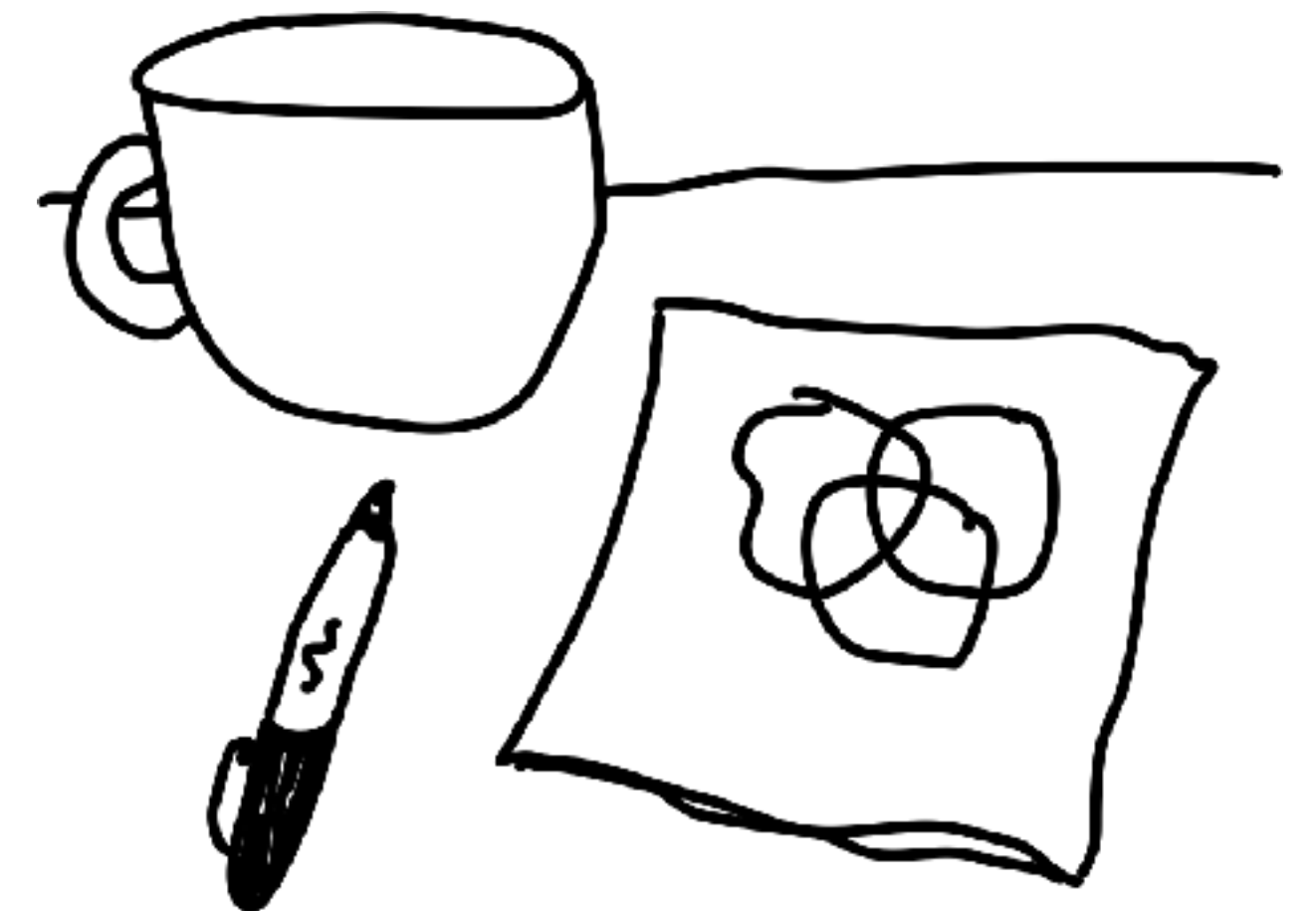
10 minutes

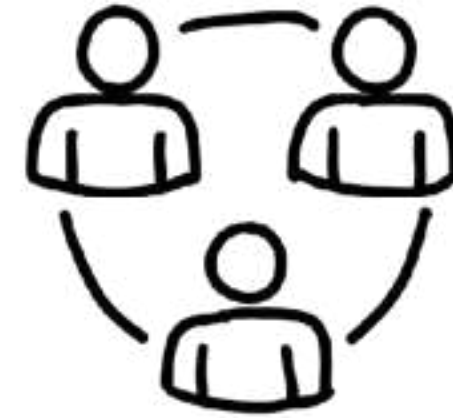
Bar napkin

- (5 minutes) Individually, think about what you learned in the interviews. **Write at least 3 key findings** on a post-it each.
- (2 min + 2 min) Pair up with someone of your group, pretend you're at a bar chatting with someone: **share your findings** and switch roles.

Ask yourself:

- What did you learn about your research goals?
- What do you think were the main user goals, motivations, uncovered needs and key problems?
- What are some key things you realized regarding the challenge?

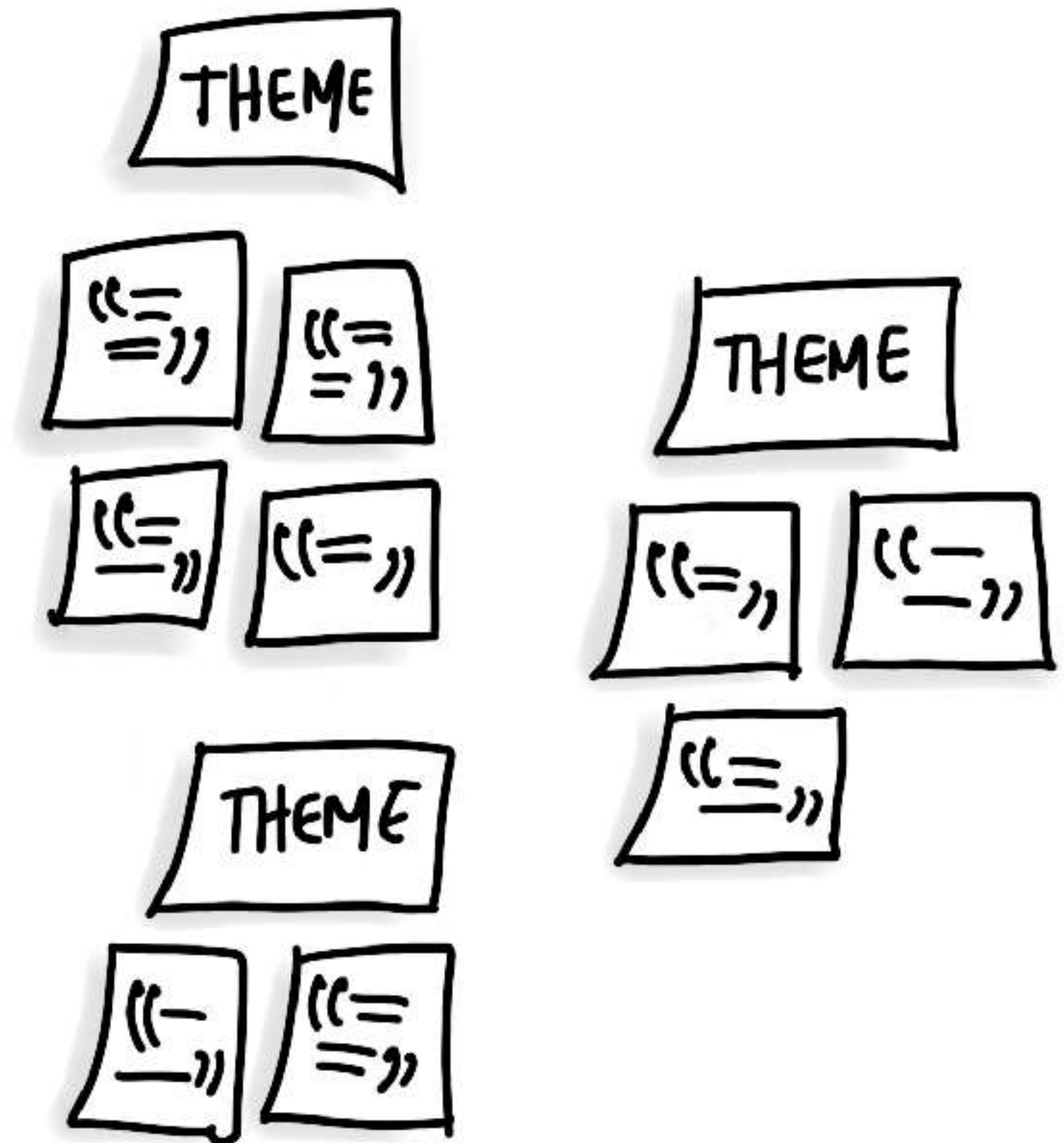




10 minutes

Synthesize

- (5 minutes) In group, share your 2-3 findings each and place it on a flipchart.
- (5 minutes) **Find patterns:**
In group organize your Post-its **per topics or themes** (ex. Use of technology, specific behaviours,...)
- Use another Post-it to **label your themes** when you're done.





10 minutes

Actionable insights

Looking at the categories you've generated, individually, write down the key insights that come from your research.

- Create **2-3 insight headlines** from your synthesis
- Add a **description** (and potentially quotes or observation from interviews) that supports the statement

Remember

- Is the insight actionable?
- Does it inspire the creative process?
- Is it sticky enough or does it have a point of view?
- Does it tell something new?
- Does it come from the research?

Understand

Creating Personas

Personas are fictional archetypes that describe the various observed **behavior patterns**, **needs** and **goals** among your potential users and customers.

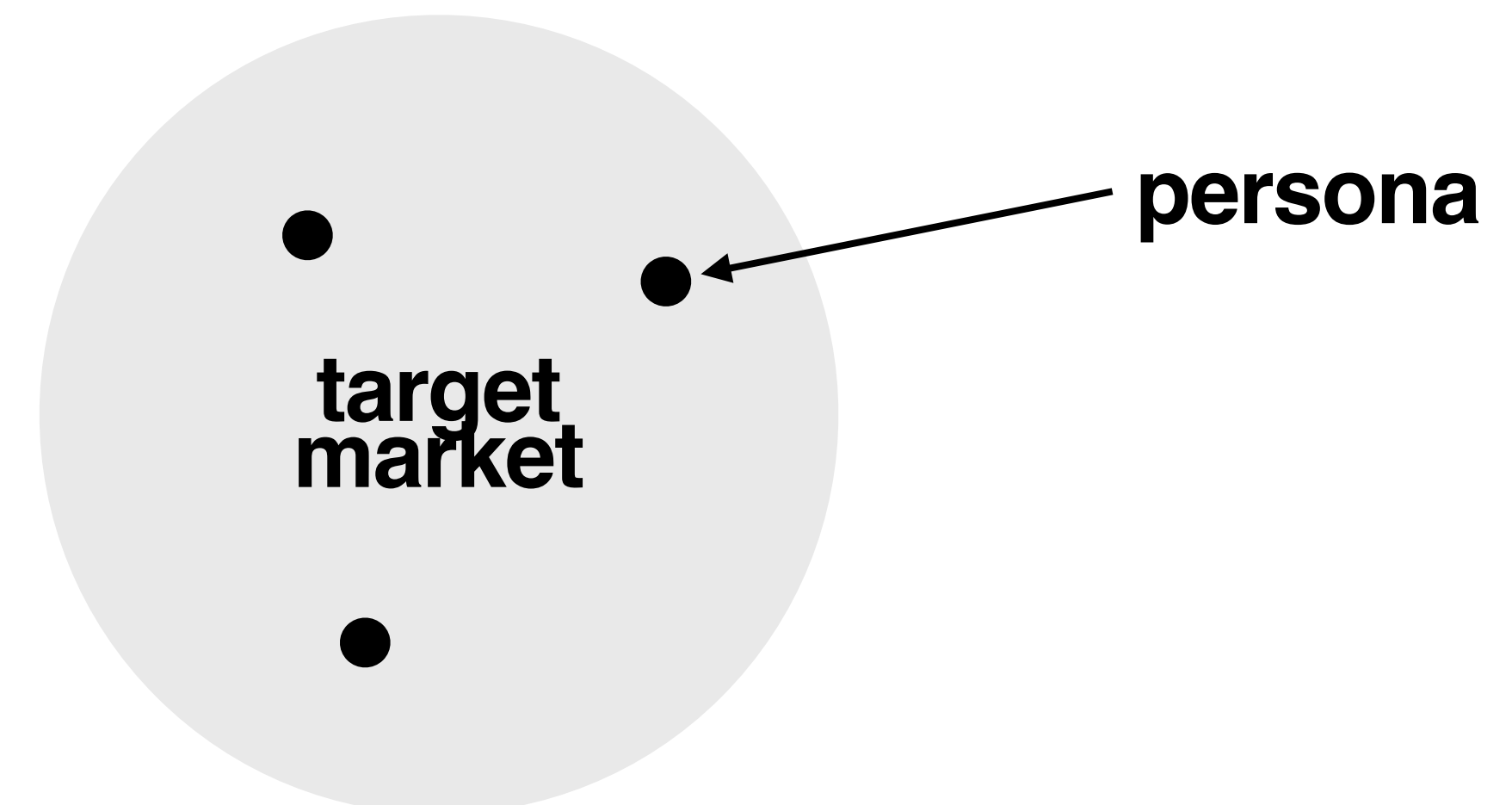
A 'Persona' is not...

- ... a representation of market segmentation**
- ... a real person that was interviewed**
- ... statistically representative of a population**
- ... a sheet of template to be filled in.**

Persona sets

Most projects have several personas.

- Sets of personas represent significant, distinct behavior patterns and goals within a target market. Be aware:
 - Some personas are completely distinct based on their activities and goals, but be judicious about simply mapping personas to roles. There may be more nuance.
 - Personas may share characteristics but they need to be different enough to provide a distinct design target.



Different ways to model people



Marketing persona



Design persona

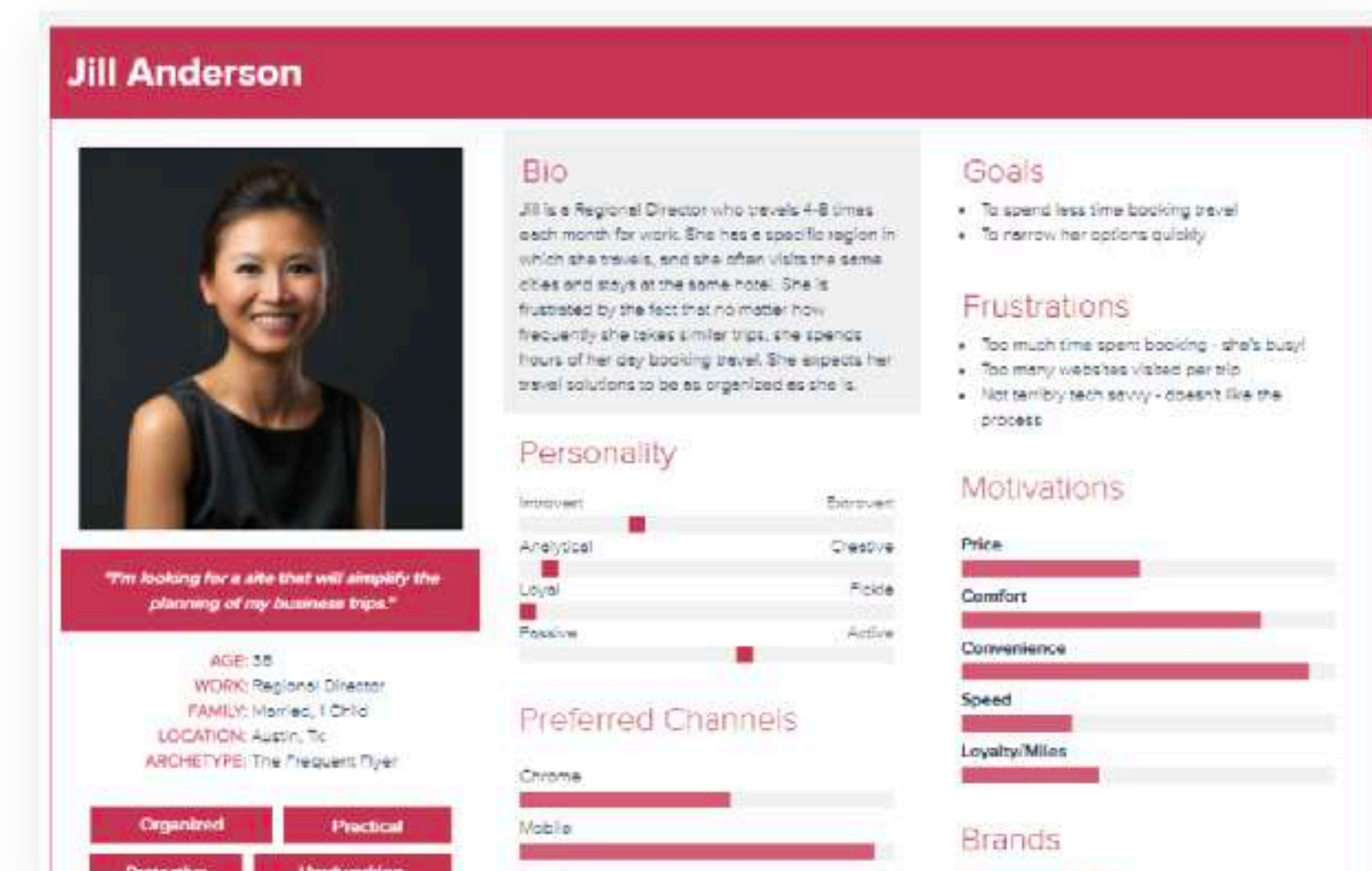


Proto-persona

Marketing personas

**Also called: Customer personas,
buyer personas, consumer models**

- A set of representative customer archetypes drawn from site analytics, social media research, surveys, interviews and expertise of salespeople.
- Explains customer behavior, but does not the “Why” behind it.
- Often emphasizes:
 - demographic information
 - shopping or buying preferences
 - marketing message
 - how the organization can help them



Design personas

Also called: Behavioral models

- A set of representative user archetypes based on the behaviors, attitudes, and goals of real people interviewed in design research.
 - Act as the voice of the user.
 - Describe why people do what they do.
 - Help everyone involved in designing and building a product or service understand, relate to, and remember the end user throughout the entire product development process.



Jordan, 29
Startup Business

LOCATION
Encinitas, CA

BUSINESS
Salvavidas Nutrition (4 yrs)

ROLE
Co-Founder & CEO

TYPE OF SERVICE
Personalized nutrition

PREVIOUS SHIPPING METHODS
shopify

INTRODUCTION TO FEDEX PAYMENT
FitSmallBusiness

AVERAGE DAILY VOLUME
60 Shipments

100% Customer Satisfaction

“I need an experienced partner who can take some of the load off so I can focus on what really matters.”

Meet Jordan

Jordan studied biochemistry and went to work for a large pharmaceutical company after graduation. After 5 years in the industry, he decided to pursue his passion project full-time and founded Salvavidas Nutrition with a friend. Their vision is to provide personalized nutrition to help people of all types optimize their biology.

Jordan handles the business and operations side of things, while his partner manages the consumer-facing side of the business. Since founding the company in 2017, they have experienced steady growth, primarily driven by their strong social media following on YouTube and Instagram, and influencer partnerships.

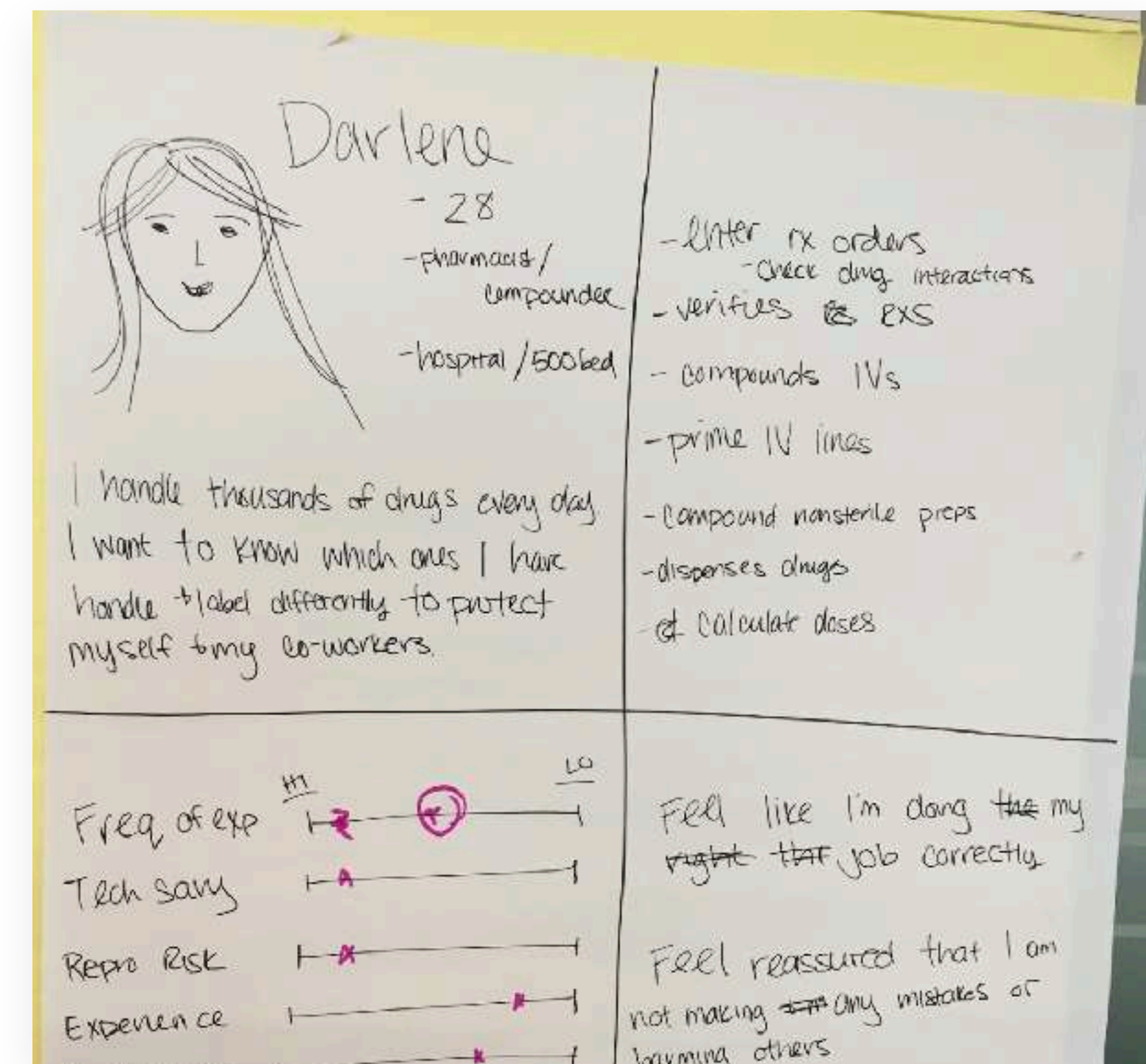
For the past 2 years they have been manufacturing their product in Utah, shipping to Jordan's home in California, and fulfilling orders themselves. They currently sell through a Shopify website, but have ambitions of distributing B2B through a partner network in the future. They deliberately avoided selling through Amazon to preserve their brand image. They recently reached a point where storing product at home and fulfilling orders themselves wasn't sustainable, and began looking for a fulfillment provider.

Jordan did a bit of online research in order to understand what his fulfillment options were, and came across [FitSmallBusiness](#) through a review article on FitSmallBusiness. Though a bit more expensive than other providers, he was willing to pay a premium in order to get the professional service he expected from an industry leader.

Proto-personas

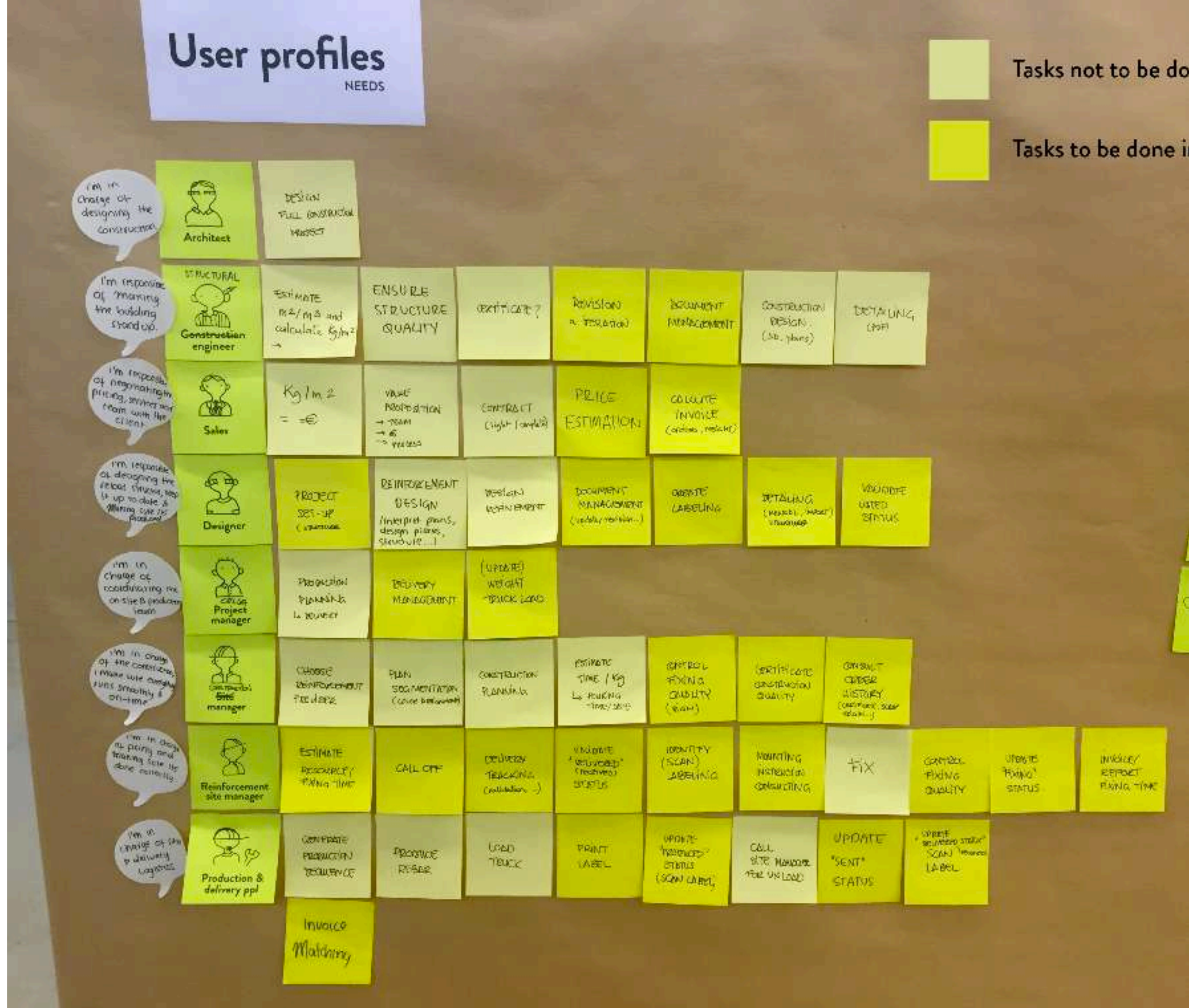
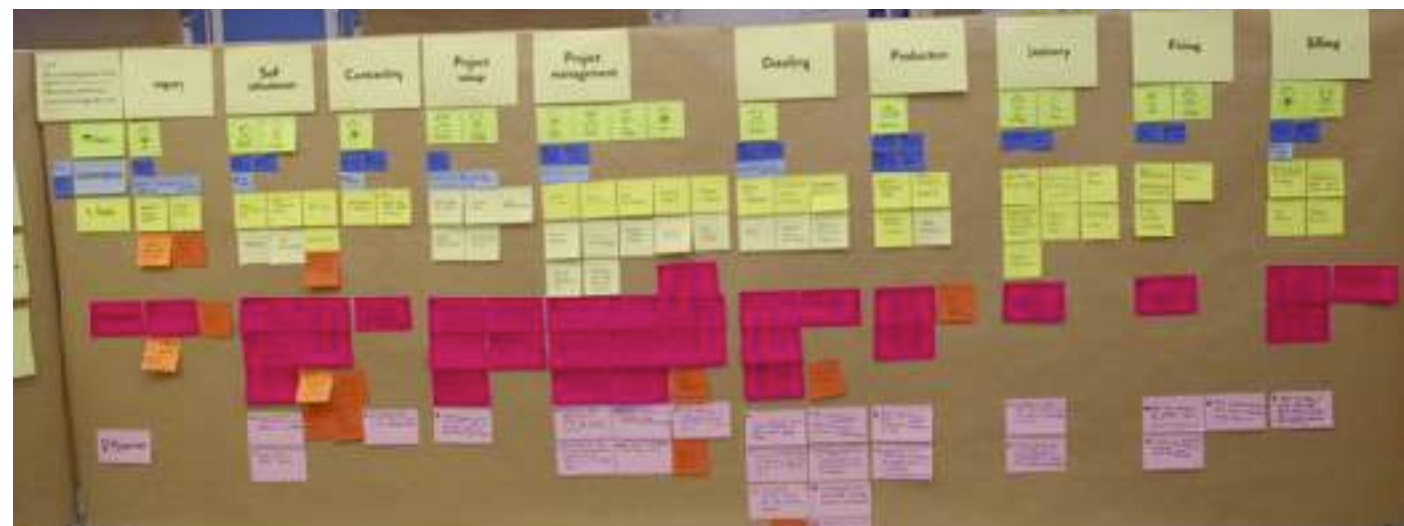
Also called: Provisional personas

- A set of fictional, representative user archetypes based on your team's educated guess at types of behaviors, attitudes, and goals of users. A hypothesis; not based on substantial research.
 - Drawn from the perspective of internal subject matter experts, like customer service representatives, or other stakeholders.
 - Can be informed by secondary research like observing behavior in forums or chat groups.
 - Better than no persona to drive design decisions!

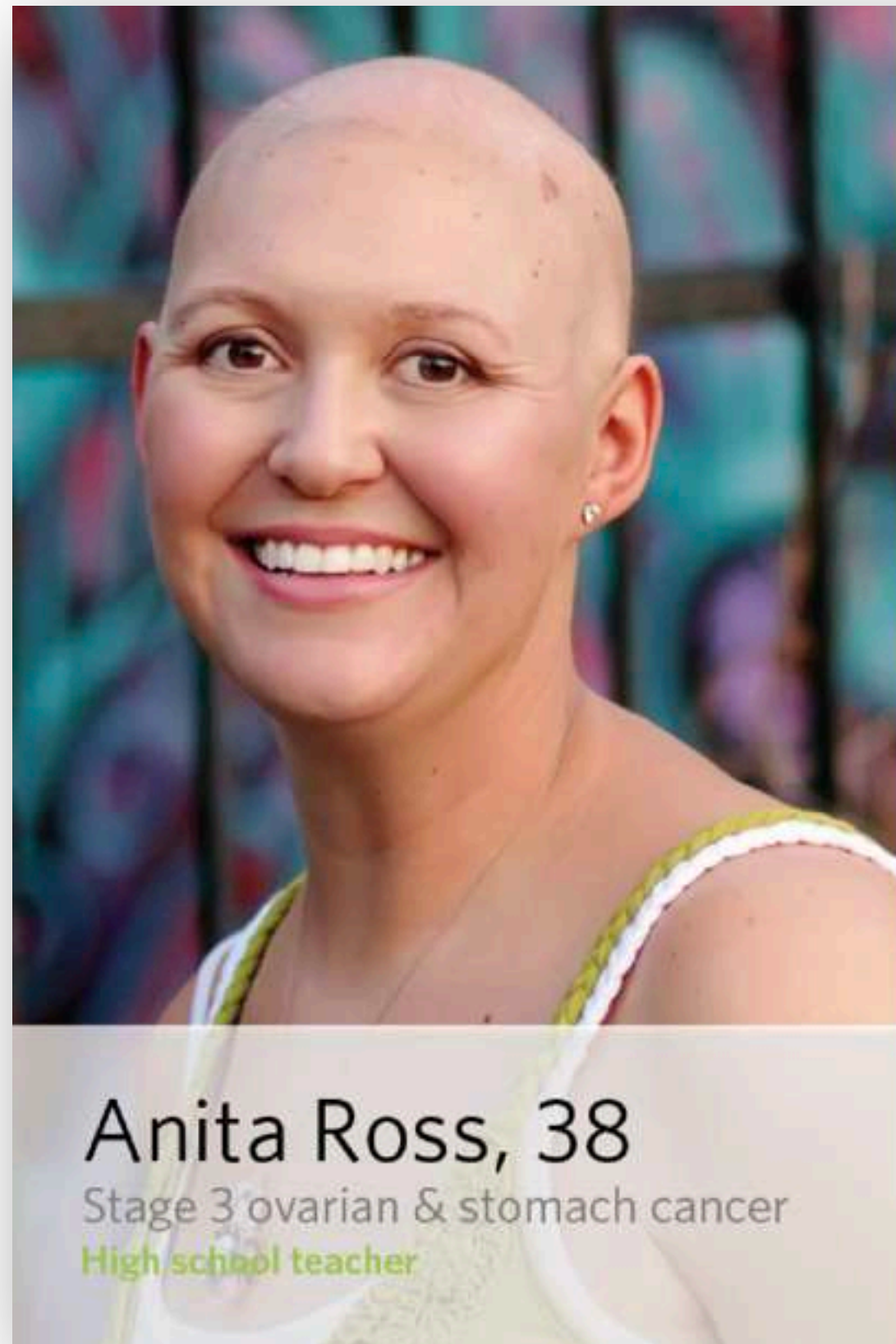


Persona ≠ stakeholders or roles

BE JUDICIOUS ABOUT SIMPLY MAPPING PERSONAS TO ROLES. THERE MAY BE MORE NUANCE.



Exploratory research



Anita Ross, 38

Stage 3 ovarian & stomach cancer

High school teacher

“My oncologist should help me understand everything.”

Goals

- + Feel confident and in control of her treatment decisions
- + Understand her illness and treatment
- + Actively look for the latest treatment options

Anita's background



- + A few years ago, Anita was diagnosed with ovarian cancer. She had surgery and chemotherapy, but it was later discovered in her stomach.
- + She often searches for the latest treatments options, looking at everything from clinical trials to alternative treatments.
- + Anita doesn't accept her situation, and challenges her care team and family to help her find a way out of having cancer. She will push them, along with herself, to look for whatever information is helpful.
- + She is highly engaged in managing her health, and keeps track of whatever she can to feel in control of her situation.
- + Her oncologist provides her with labs and scans, which she reviews and files. She feels empowered and confident when she understands information about her treatment.



Kostya
30-Ecomindset



He is very concerned about his **environmental footprint**, and sees his actions as a consumer from a moral point of view.

He is not driven by facts or trends, but by **the desire to achieve his sustainable life objectives** and if the products will be **durability and repairable**.

For him, his objectives are a life mission, **technology may be a means to achieve them**, not an end in itself.

He is a big technology enthusiast, but he likes to feel like he is in command of technology and not the other way around.

He considers himself to be an expert user, he wants to be able to **hack and manipulate technological devices**. He is a big fan of open source software and has made a few devices with Arduino.

He is not driven by facts or trends, he focuses 100% on **features, functionality and the ability to personalise the technology to fit his needs**.

GAINS +

- He does **DIY** with a technical perspective. He likes going back to the roots and understanding how things work, especially if it's mechanical and physical.
- He would appreciate if all the solutions he uses were built with **functionality and simplicity** rather than being too complex.
- He trusts companies that have an **ethical engagement** and whose values align with his own. He will go the extra mile to find out if they really do.

— PAINS

- Sometimes he uses technology as a **means to an end** rather than a **goal in itself**.
- He would not like fully automated solutions that would prevent him from **learning something new**.

TECHNOLOGY

He is a big fan of open source software and hardware. He likes to be able to **hack and manipulate technological devices**. He is a big fan of open source software and has made a few devices with Arduino.

HOME LIVING

He is not driven by facts or trends, but by the desire to achieve his sustainable life objectives and if the products will be durability and repairable.

LIFESTYLE

He is very concerned about his environmental footprint, and sees his actions as a consumer from a moral point of view.

HOME IMPROVEMENT

He is not driven by facts or trends, but by the desire to achieve his sustainable life objectives and if the products will be durability and repairable.



Sylvain
32-Tech-Geek



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GAINS +

- He wants to be in control of the technological solutions he buys. He wants to be able to **hack and manipulate technological devices**. He is a big fan of open source software and has made a few devices with Arduino.
- He likes a sense of achievement when doing this and a sense of pride because he is building things that are unique.
- He enjoys building something and watching technology fit his needs.

— PAINS

- He doesn't plug and play solutions that do not have enough personalisation options.
- He doesn't like closed software and planned obsolescence. He is the typical guy that complains because he cannot change the iPhone battery.
- If he can't find a product that works for him, he will try to build it on his own.

TECHNOLOGY

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Main characteristic as a name



Kasia
43-Gadget Parent



She is a very busy woman, who runs her own business and has three children. Thus, she will look for solutions that **save her time and effort at home**. If they allow her to **multitask, even better**.

She is not knowledgeable about technology and she does not really care about how something works as long as **it works for her and it is easy to use** without reading a manual. She asks her teenage son to set up and teach her how to use the devices.

She is a big fan of open source software and hardware. She likes to be able to **hack and manipulate technological devices**. She is a big fan of open source software and has made a few devices with Arduino.

She is not driven by facts or trends, but by the desire to achieve her sustainable life objectives and if the products will be durability and repairable.

For her, her objectives are a life mission, technology may be a means to achieve them, not an end in itself.

GAINS +

- She likes plug and play solutions that are easy to install and easy to use.
- She needs to have everything installed in plain language and without any technical jargon.
- She would also be interested in solutions that can be used to **manage private moments**.

— PAINS

- She does not have time to go to tech and course events. She prefers to stay online that sometimes she can't understand or built the products as she self-educates.
- Because she is not comfortable around the technicalities of technology she needs a lot of guidance and support. She will make the effort to go to a shop to ask for an expert's help.

TECHNOLOGY

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Valentina
33-Connected nomad



She is always looking for novelty and to try new things, whether it's technology or the best restaurant.

She is not very knowledgeable about technology so she uses the brand as a **guide to choose between one product or another**.

She sees the smartphone as the center of her connected world. She also has a smart watch and is open to experiment new ways to interact with technology.

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For her, her objectives are a life mission, technology may be a means to achieve them, not an end in itself.

GAINS +

- She likes to be seen as a trend setter by her community.
- She likes products that she can show off as status items.
- She would appreciate solutions that she can control with her smartphone and that integrate seamlessly with her social networks.

— PAINS

- She would not buy devices that are not compatible and can't be seamlessly integrated with her existing devices.
- She does not have the patience to deal with technical issues, with very interactive experiences or that need a steep learning curve.
- She prefers short posts or reels to watch and control devices that she can take with her when she changes location.

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5 minutes

Find 3 behavioral patterns

Find 3 personas that represent the differentiate way people experience or address the problem:

- In group, define 3 different personas.
- Choose a **primary persona** for your future solution.



Examples

Stress driven / Pleasure driven / Curiosity driven

Pro / Amateur / Newbie

Technical / Business / Admin role

Traditional / Geek / Nomad...

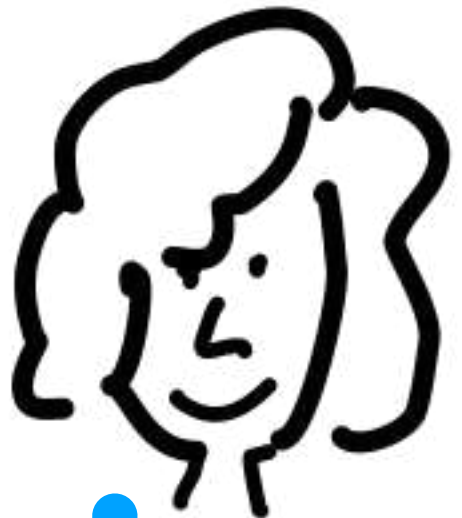


10 minutes

Create a persona

Name, descriptive title (ex. ecoconscious), picture (or drawing) and quote to give a sense of the persona's mental model

What do they want to achieve? How do they want to feel? What ultimately motivates them?

 Sara Wells " ~~~~~ ~~~~~ ~~~~~"	Sara's story ~~~~~ ~~~~~ ~~~~~ ~~~~~
Goals • ~~~~~ ~~~~~ • ~~~~~ ~~~~~ • ~~~~~ ~~~~~	Behaviors • ~~~~~ ~~~~~ • ~~~~~ ~~~~~ • ~~~~~ ~~~~~

Provide background and context for this persona

What are the relevant behaviors that tell us more about how this persona operates to achieve their goals?

Understand

User Journey Mapping

A user journey is a representation of a sequence of moments (like a timeline) that a user experiences when using our solution.

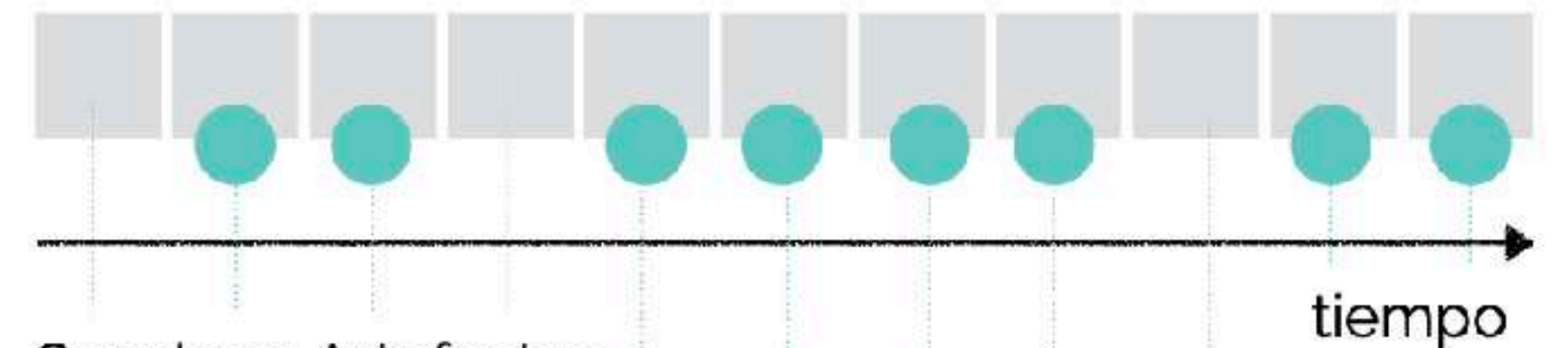
Etapas de la historia

Antes

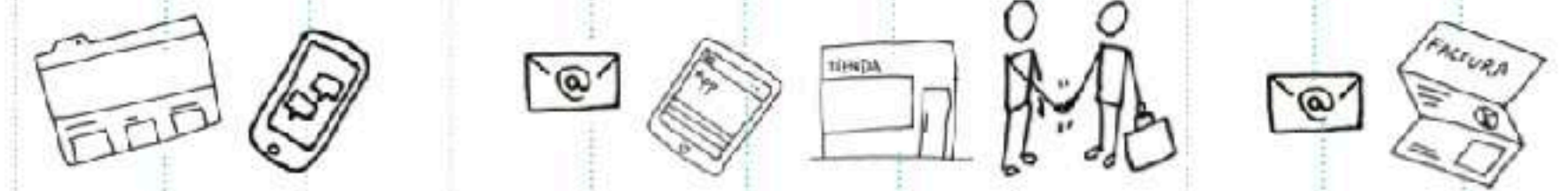
Durante (con sub-etapas)

Después

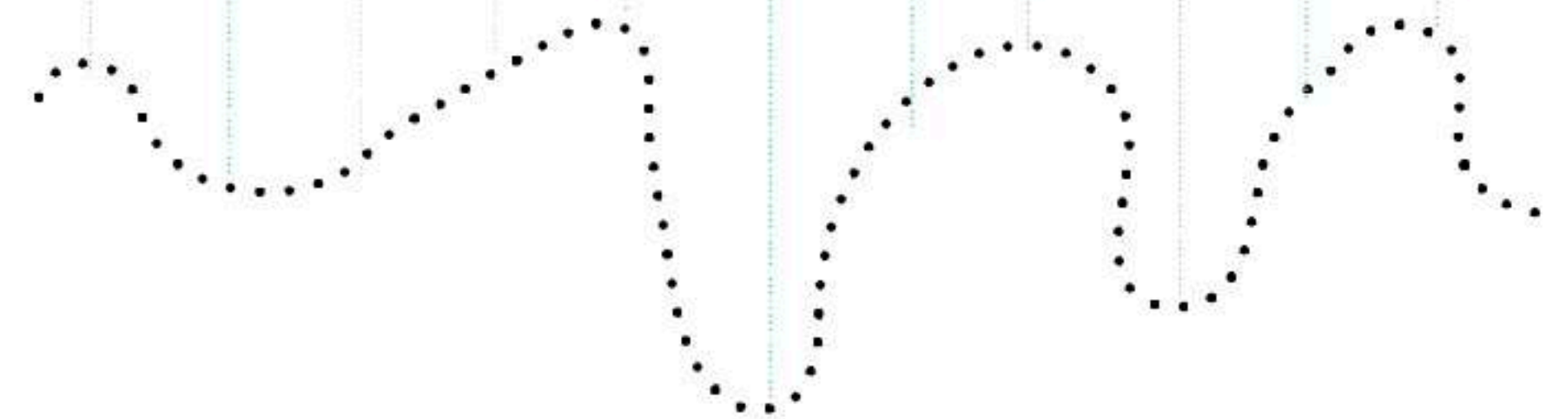
Momentos del usuario



Canales y Artefactos



Emociones u otro aspecto



A journey map is a visualization of the steps involved in a service or product experience, across channels and touchpoints.

Understand

Synthesis

Channels vs. Touchpoints

Channels = the overall medium

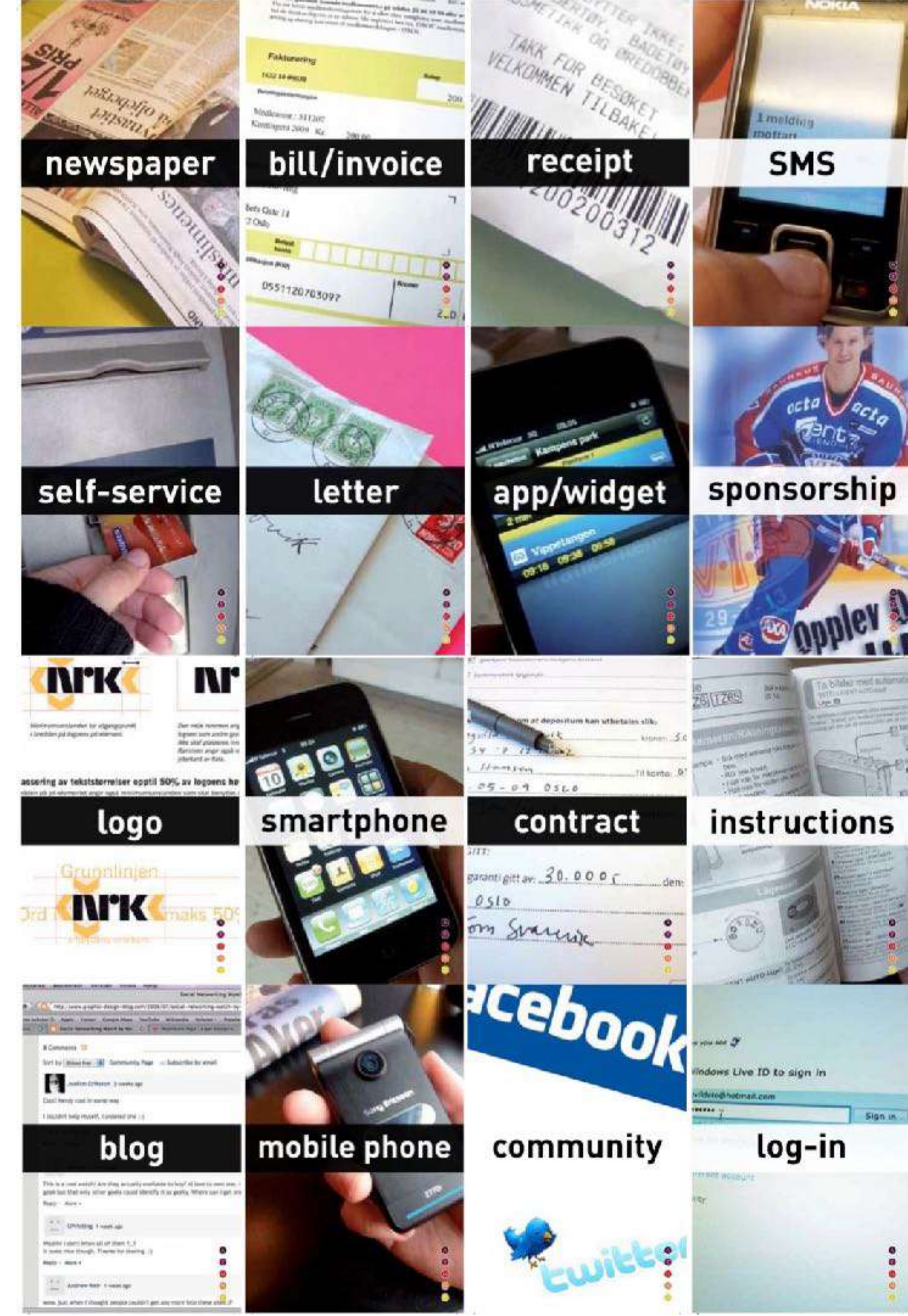
For example: SMS, website, reception desk

Touchpoints = single moments of interaction within a channel

For example: Welcome text, log-in screen, check-in process

Aurelie
Glorieux

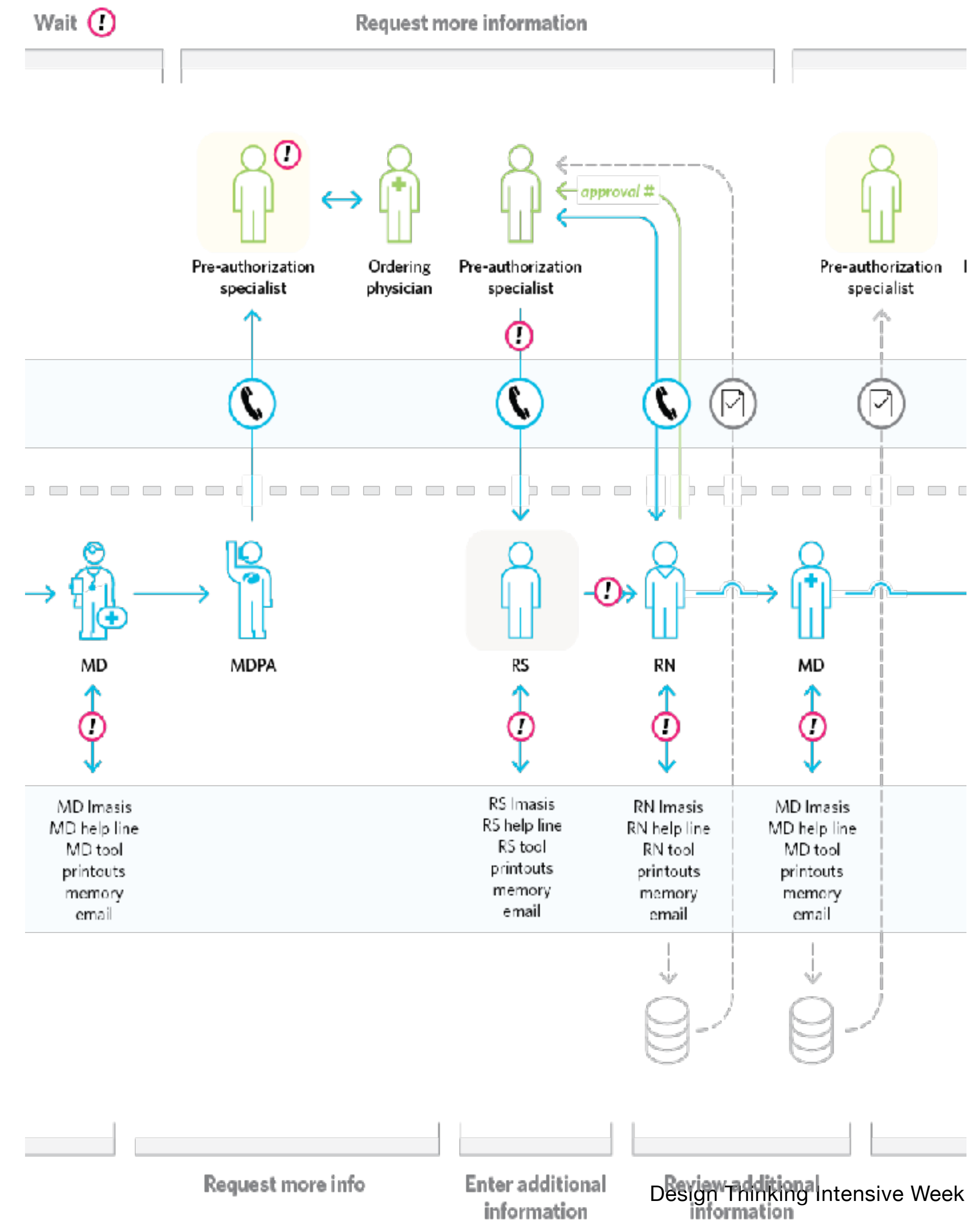
esade



Actors

Services implies various actors:

- Clients or users
- Actors over the line of visibility
- Actors under the line of visibility
- ¿Others hidden actors?



Understand

Synthesis

User Journey (as is)

A TOOL TO
UNDERSTAND THE
CURRENT
EXPERIENCE (AS IS)



User Journey (to be)

A TOOL TO DEFINE
THE FUTURE SERVICE
(TO BE)



How to build it

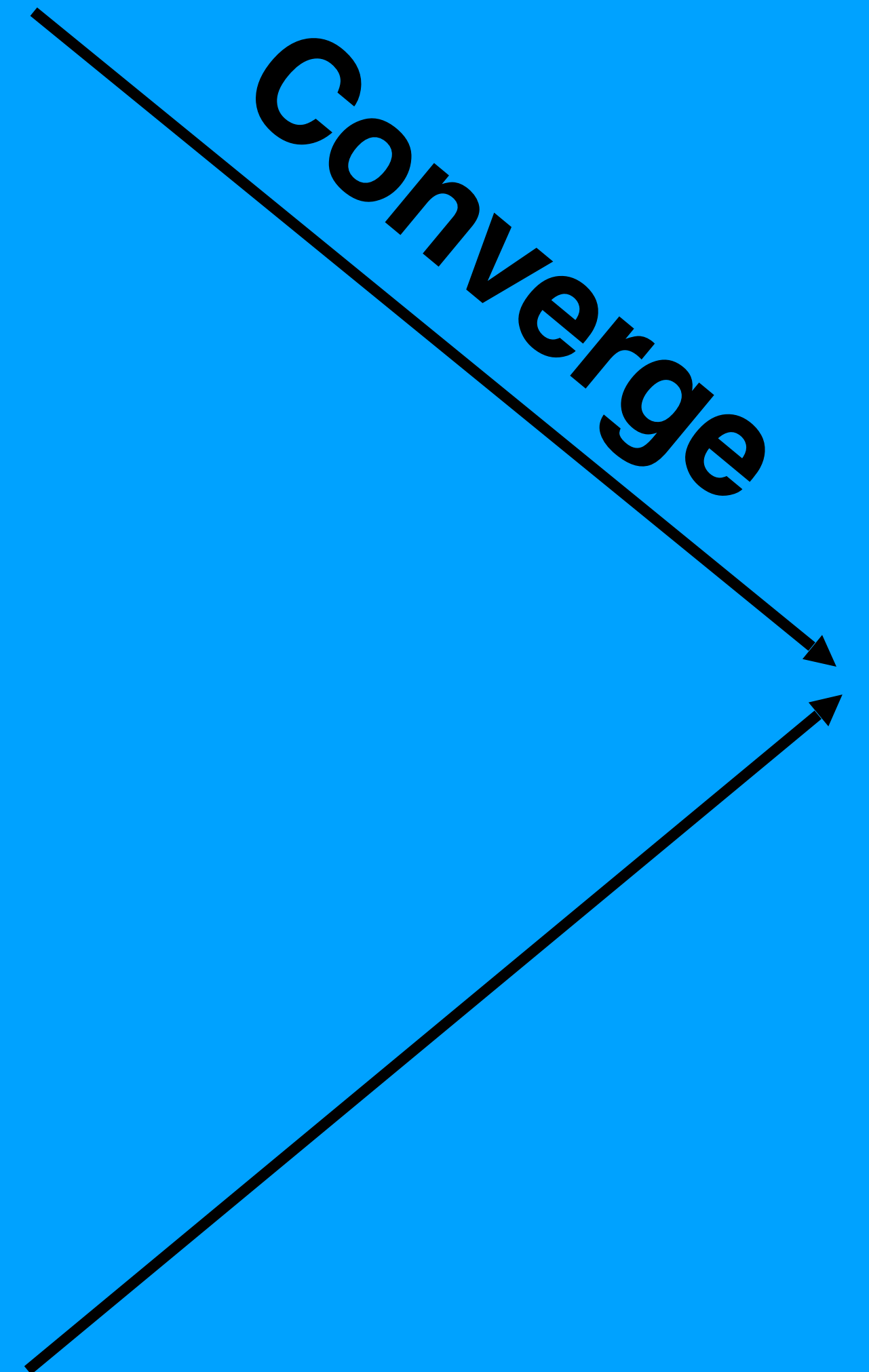
1. Identify all the **moments** of the experience.
2. Define **who** lives/participates in the experience. Who is the main character? We have to tell the story from that person's perspective.
3. Show **what the user does**, thinks and feels at every moment in order to understand the opportunities presented by the user
4. Identify **relevant actors** and **artifacts**, **critical points**, **moments of truth**, **opportunities** for improvement.



Understand

Your challenge

Journey Mapping



Synthesis

The level of fidelity for today:





30 minutes

Journey mapping

Use your notes from the interview to map out the basic user journey of the user experience.

Create swim lanes using tape/marker and Post-it's

- User actions (per actors)
- Positive experience (motivations, delight, ease..)
- Negative experience (painpoints, difficulties, cause of negative emotions)
- Touchpoints involved





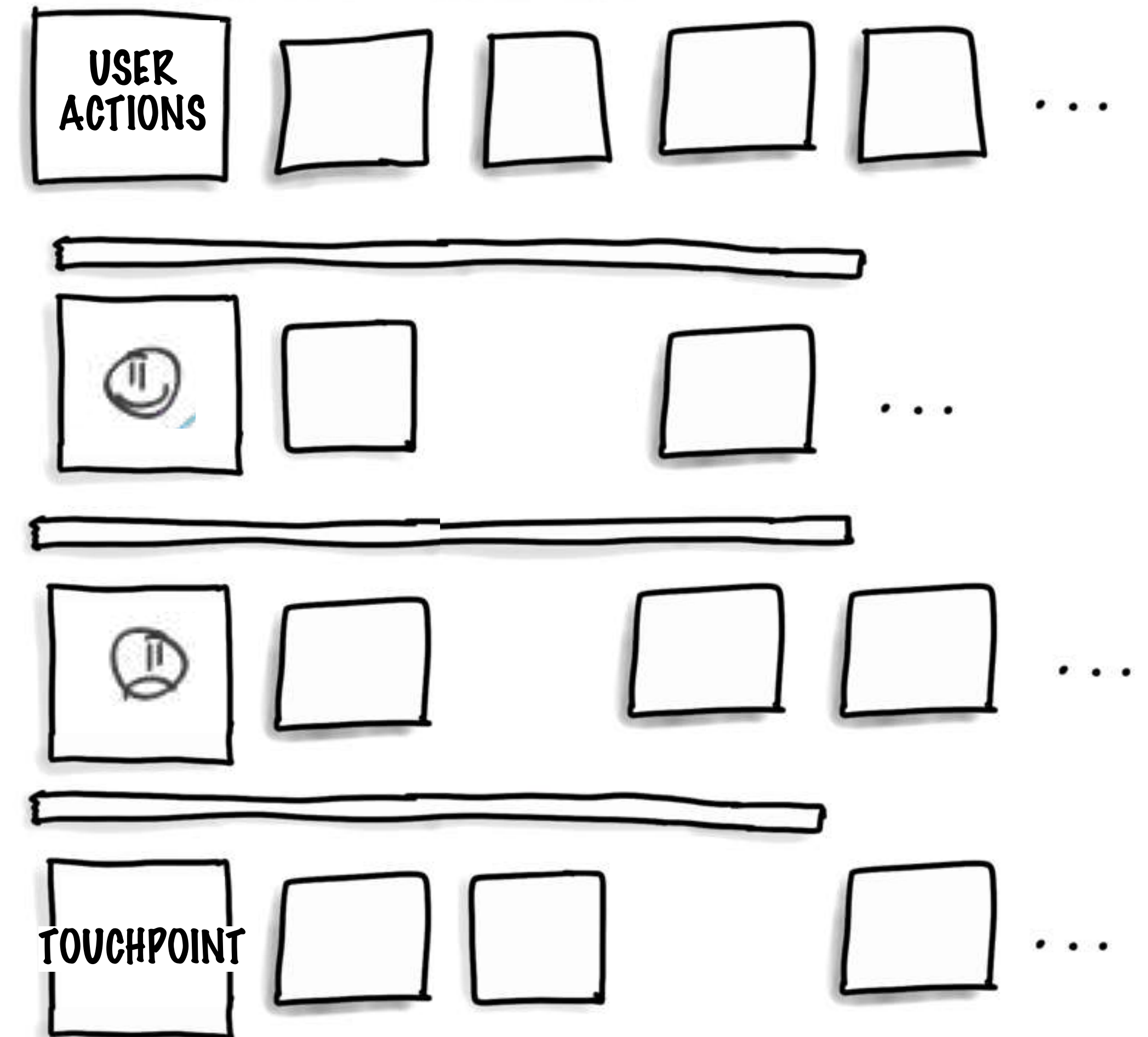
30 minutes

Journey mapping

Use your notes from the interview to map out the basic user journey of the user experience.

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10 minutes



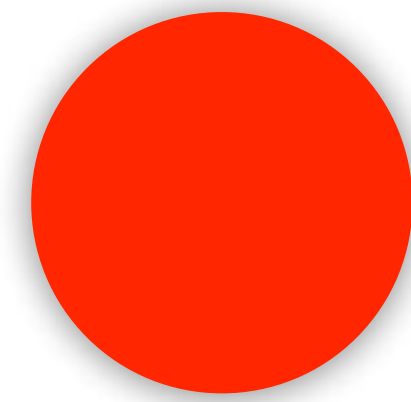
Annotate your map

With 3 red dots

- Select the critical moment or painpoints that could be improved or solved

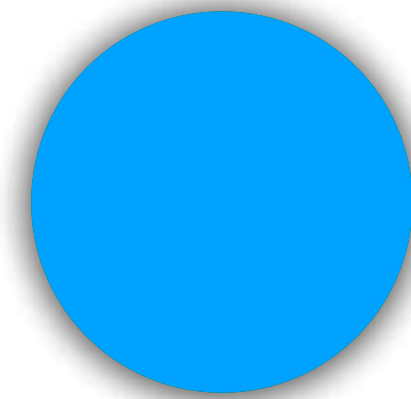
With 3 blue dots

- Select the moments that could be good for an innovative idea or new approach.



Main Painpoints

Drop-off points, what's not working, emotional lows, etc.



Opportunities

Moments that are ripe for an innovative idea or new approach.



10 minutes



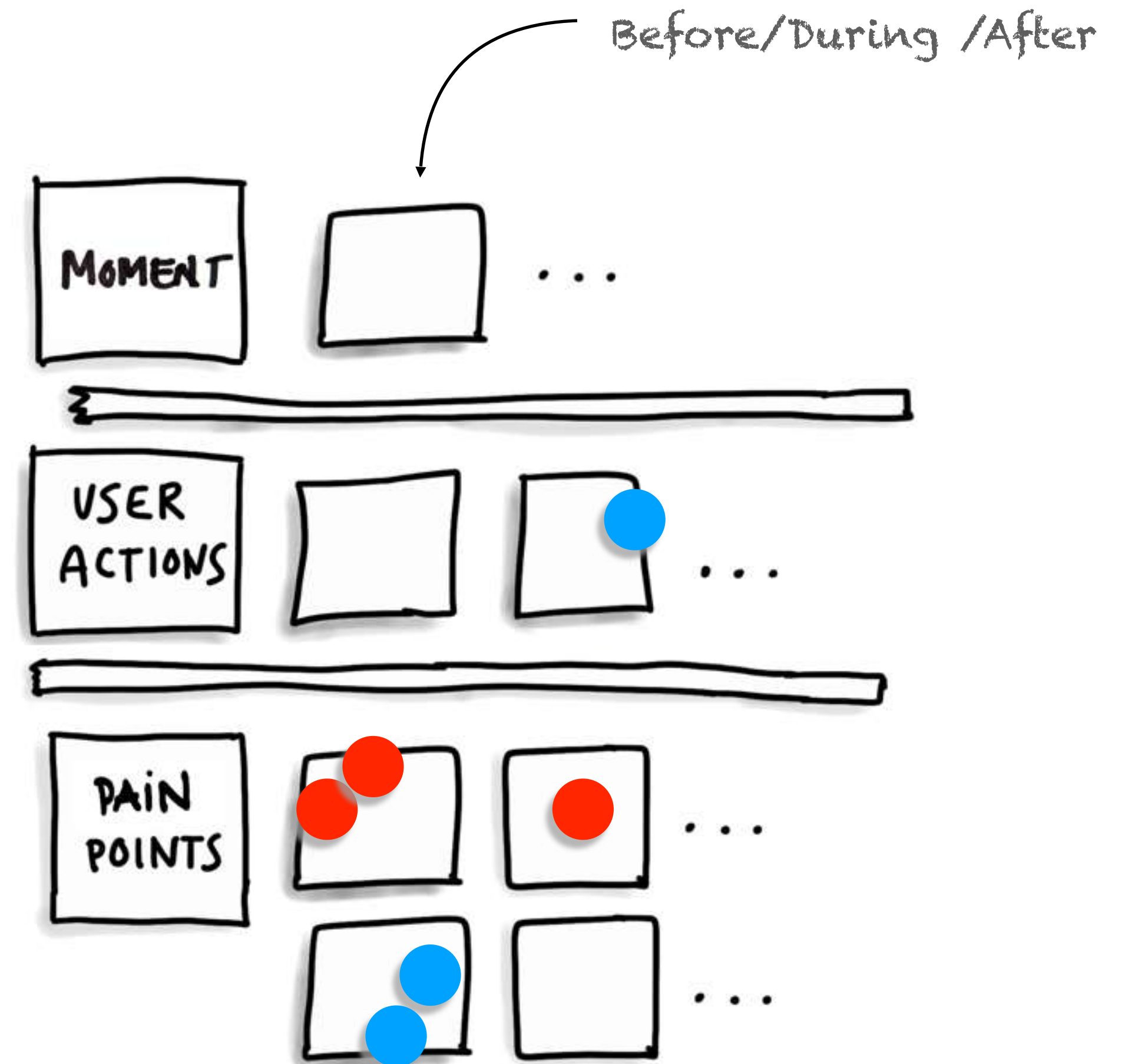
Select & detect opportunity

With 3 red dots

- Select the critical moments or painpoints that could be improved or solved

With 3 blue dots

- Select the moments that could be good for an innovative idea or new approach.
- Share and select.





10 minutes



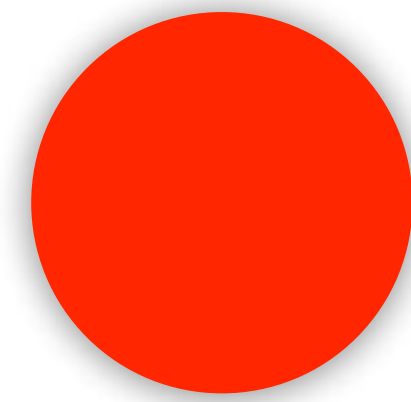
Annotate your map

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- Select the critical moment or painpoints that could be improved or solved

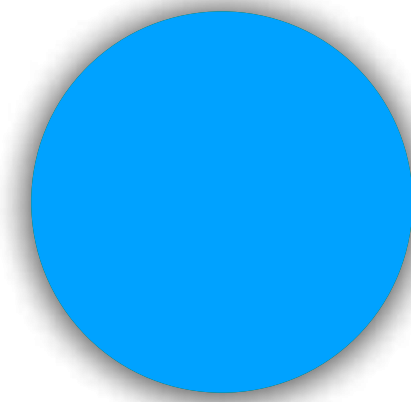
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Main Painpoints

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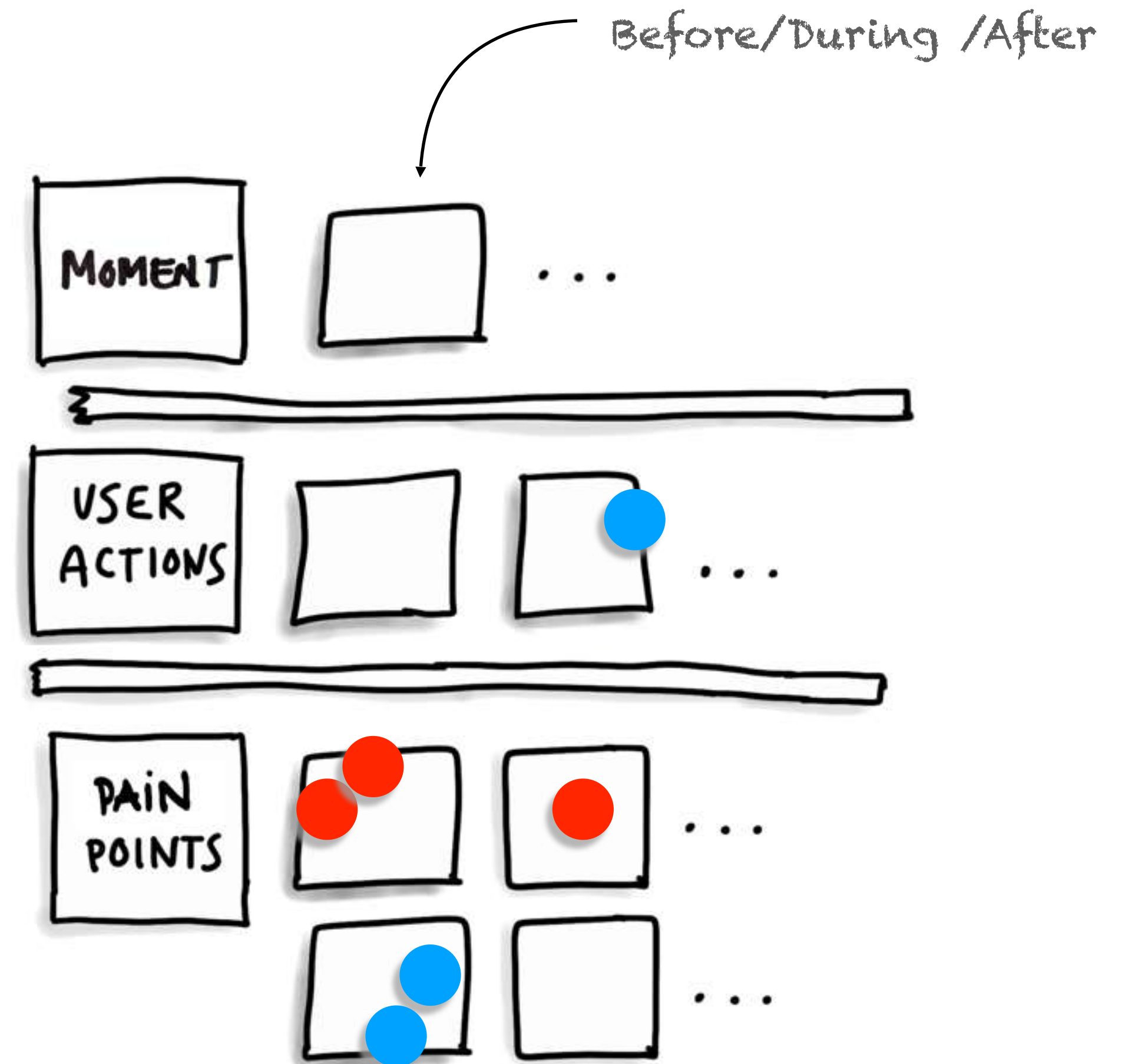
Select & detect opportunity

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- Select the critical moments or painpoints that could be improved or solved

With 3 blue dots

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Your project

Interview Summary

Template

Delivery requirement:
One interview summary
per interview

NAME OF INTERVIEWER Date and format (face-to-face or online). NAME OF INTERVIEWEE DESCRIPTION OF PROFILE	INTERVIEW NOTES: KEY LEARNINGS Highlight main findings. Specially about the main user needs, painpoints, wishes or motivations and goals (what they are trying to achieve). Highlight key leanings for your challenge. What is a new information? Include 1 – 2 verbatim from the interview that reflect the user’s behavior regarding the studied topics.	IMPLICATIONS FOR CHALLENGE
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10 minutes



Actionable insights

Looking at the categories you've generated, individually, write down the key insights that come from your research.

- Create **3 insight headlines** from your synthesis
- Add a **description** (and potentially quotes or observation from interviews) that supports the statement

Remember

- Is the insight actionable?
- Does it inspire the creative process?
- Is it sticky enough or does it have a point of view?
- Does it tell something new?
- Does it come from the research?

Delivery requirement:

At least 3 insights per project.



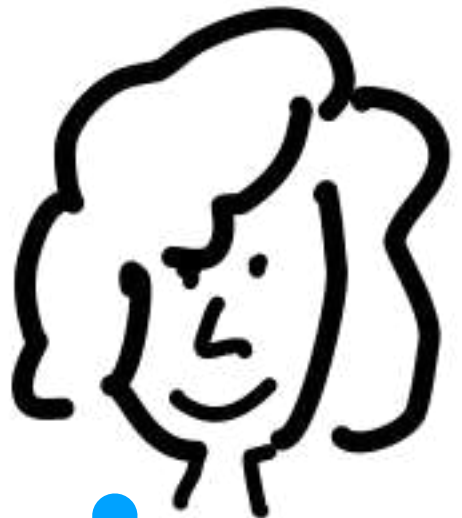
10 minutes

Create a persona

Delivery requirement:
At least, one primary
persona per project.

Name, descriptive title
(ex. ecoconscious),
picture (drawing) and
quote to give a sense
of the persona's
mental model

What do they want to
achieve? How do
they want to feel?
What ultimately
motivates them?

 Sara Wells " ~~~~~ ~~~~~ ~~~~~"	Sara's story ~~~~~ ~~~~~ ~~~~~ ~~~~~
Goals • ~~~~~ ~~~~~ • ~~~~~ ~~~~~ • ~~~~~ ~~~~~	Behaviors • ~~~~~ ~~~~~ • ~~~~~ ~~~~~ • ~~~~~ ~~~~~

Provide background
and context for this
persona

What are the relevant
behaviors that tell us
more about how this
persona operates to
achieve their goals?



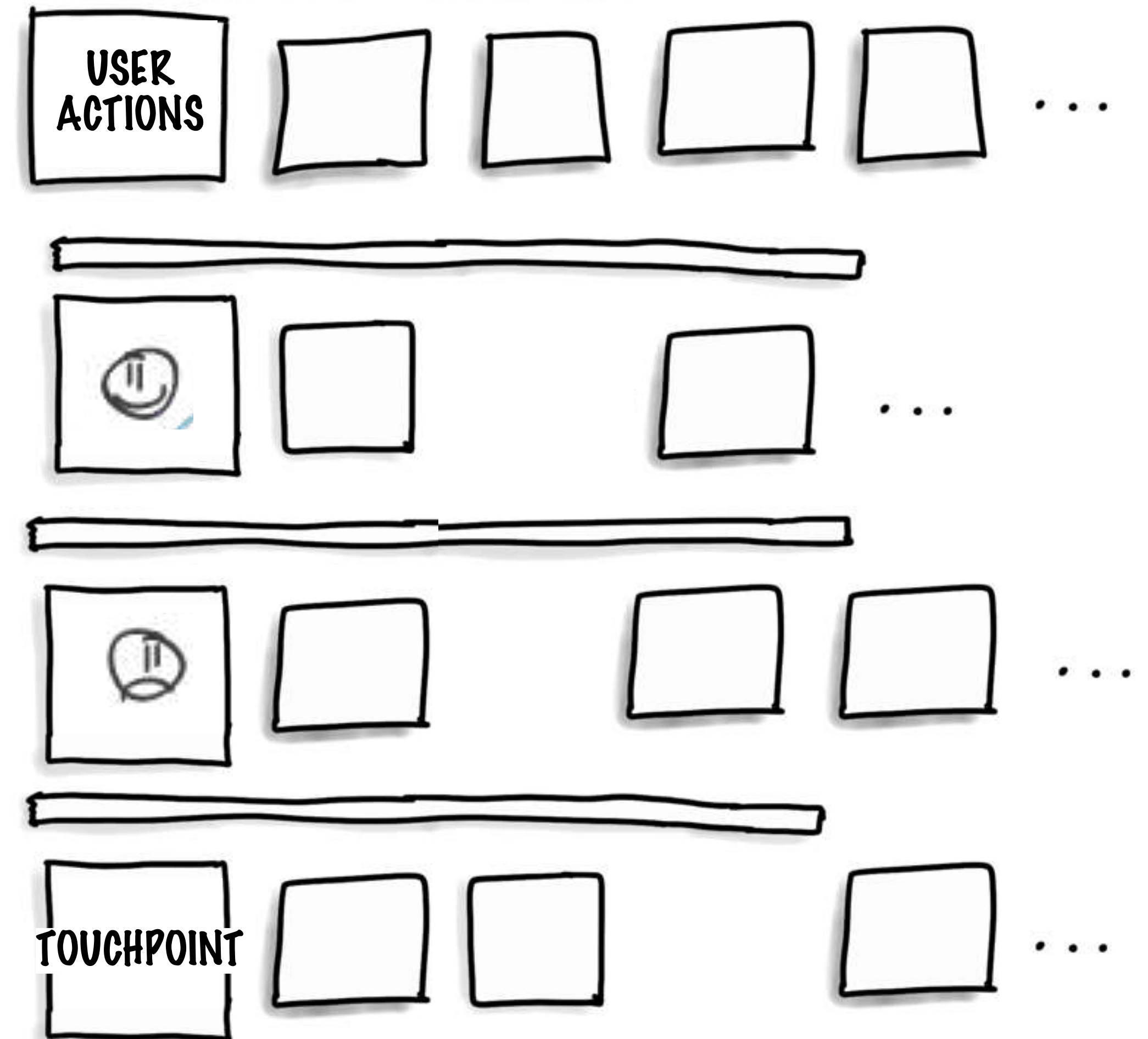
30 minutes

Journey mapping

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Create swim lanes using tape/marker and Post-it's

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- Positive experience (motivations, delight, ease..)
- Negative experience (painpoints, difficulties, cause of negative emotions)
- Touchpoints involved



Delivery requirement:

At least, one user journey of the main persona.